

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · September 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	73.8
#2	A+	Salt Lake City	72.2
#3	A+	St. Louis	71.6
#4	A+	Cincinnati	71.4
#5	A+	Hartford	70.5
#6	A+	Kansas City	69.7
#7	A	Charlotte	66.9

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	C-	Detroit	26.9
#49	C-	Louisville	27.0
#48	C-	Chicago	27.5
#47	C-	Jacksonville	28.6
#46	C-	Richmond	30.4
#45	C	Fresno	32.5
#44	C	Grand Rapids	33.3

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	23 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	0 cities

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · September 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	73.8	3.2%	+3.2%	+2.2%	+0.5%	59 days
2	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	72.2	3.5%	+4.5%	+2.5%	+1.1%	57 days
3	St. Louis St. Louis	A+	71.6	3.8%	+3.5%	+0.7%	+0.5%	45 days
4	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	71.4	3.7%	+8.1%	+0.3%	-0.2%	42 days
5	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	70.5	2.7%	+5.3%	+1.9%	+2.8%	36 days
6	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	69.7	3.8%	+7.3%	+0.7%	+0.3%	50 days
7	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A	66.9	3.7%	+4.2%	+1.5%	-0.7%	61 days
8	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A	63.8	4.2%	+2.1%	+0.8%	+1.4%	48 days
9	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	63.0	4.0%	+5.1%	+1.2%	+0.8%	73 days
10	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A-	61.0	5.4%	+4.2%	+1.5%	+1.0%	58 days
11	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	58.7	4.6%	+4.0%	+1.0%	+0.8%	58 days
12	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	58.5	3.7%	+3.3%	-0.1%	+1.6%	53 days
13	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	57.2	4.7%	+6.1%	+0.8%	+0.2%	75 days
14	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	54.4	4.1%	-0.8%	+1.6%	-0.5%	36 days
15	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B	54.0	4.2%	+6.0%	-0.5%	-0.0%	44 days
16	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	53.1	5.0%	+5.4%	+0.9%	-0.8%	45 days
17	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	52.5	4.8%	+5.1%	+0.9%	-0.5%	74 days
18	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	52.1	3.2%	+3.1%	-0.5%	+0.9%	59 days
19	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	B	52.0	3.1%	+3.9%	+0.7%	-0.9%	60 days
20	Columbus Columbus	B	51.7	3.2%	+4.2%	+0.1%	-1.4%	44 days
21	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	50.9	4.4%	+5.8%	+0.6%	-1.7%	38 days
22	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B	50.7	3.7%	+7.7%	+0.3%	-0.2%	85 days
23	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	49.4	3.4%	+0.9%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
24	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	49.1	5.0%	+3.4%	+1.8%	-2.2%	53 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	48.3	4.0%	+5.8%	-2.0%	-2.2%	43 days
26	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	47.6	5.1%	+1.2%	+1.3%	+0.3%	52 days
27	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	B-	46.2	4.7%	+3.7%	+0.5%	+0.1%	68 days
28	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	45.8	4.3%	+1.9%	+0.5%	+0.6%	56 days
29	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	45.4	3.9%	+2.9%	-0.1%	+2.9%	51 days
30	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	45.2	4.1%	+2.1%	+0.1%	-1.7%	57 days
31	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	45.0	4.3%	+4.2%	+0.7%	-0.5%	55 days
32	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	45.0	3.5%	+0.0%	+0.9%	-1.1%	59 days
33	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	B-	44.2	3.9%	+5.5%	-0.6%	-0.9%	40 days
34	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	43.1	4.3%	+3.1%	+0.6%	+1.7%	39 days
35	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C+	41.8	4.7%	+7.5%	+0.7%	-1.8%	45 days
36	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	41.4	4.8%	+3.3%	+0.9%	-2.7%	67 days
37	Memphis Memphis	C+	40.5	4.7%	+4.5%	-0.5%	-0.9%	68 days
38	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C+	40.4	4.4%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-1.3%	39 days
39	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C+	39.8	4.9%	+5.7%	-1.5%	-0.6%	61 days
40	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C+	38.8	5.0%	+2.0%	+0.8%	-1.9%	50 days
41	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	36.4	3.8%	+0.5%	-0.2%	+0.8%	36 days
42	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C	35.4	5.7%	+5.5%	+0.8%	-1.8%	63 days
43	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	33.8	3.4%	+0.6%	-1.1%	-1.0%	51 days
44	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C	33.3	4.3%	+1.4%	+0.7%	-7.5%	38 days
45	Fresno Fresno	C	32.5	7.7%	+4.5%	+0.8%	-1.4%	57 days
46	Richmond Richmond	C-	30.4	3.8%	+2.4%	-0.8%	-0.9%	44 days
47	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C-	28.6	4.9%	+1.3%	+0.1%	-0.3%	65 days
48	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	27.5	4.9%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-2.5%	36 days
49	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	27.0	4.8%	+1.7%	-0.1%	+0.2%	44 days
50	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	26.9	6.0%	+1.5%	-0.2%	+0.7%	40 days

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

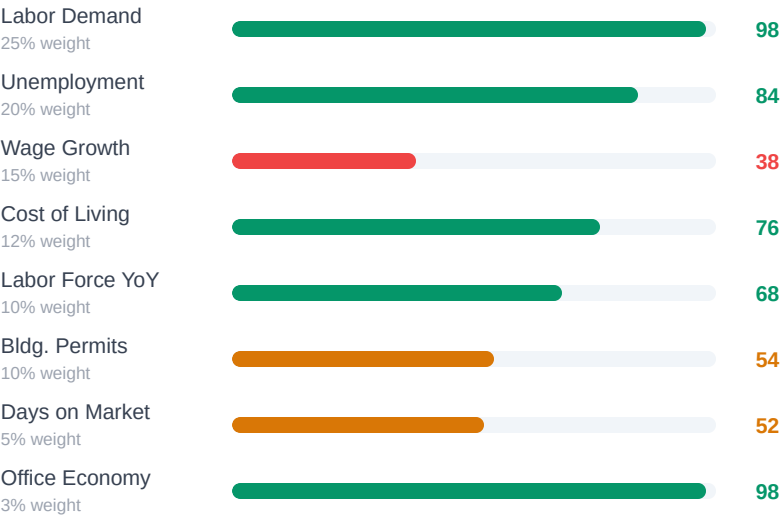
A+

EXCELLENT

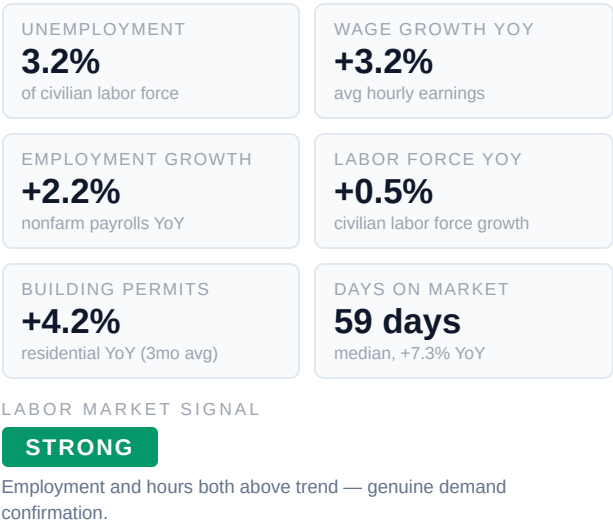
73.8th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.8th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 8.63, and its low unemployment rate of 3.20%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of a 2.23% employment growth rate and a 1.207% weekly hours deviation from trend also highlights the city's strong job market.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has seen a 2.23% employment growth rate and a 1.207% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with hours worked above the trend line, suggesting that businesses are actively seeking to hire and expand their operations. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.20%, which is in the top tier of unemployment rates, indicating a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available talent, and wage pressure may be higher due to the limited supply of workers. As a result, companies looking to hire in this market may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.16%, which is below average, ranking 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. However, this also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing as rapidly as in other cities, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living percentile rank of 76th, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The city's PSF of \$215/sqft, which is decreasing by 2.3% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly earnings of \$38.60/hr, results in a ratio of 5.57. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.48% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 68th percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply suggests that the city's hiring capacity is increasing, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need. However, the growth rate is not exceptionally high, indicating a relatively stable labor market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 4.15% year-over-year, which is near the median. This moderate growth in building permits suggests that the city's housing supply is expanding, but not at a rapid pace. As a result, future affordability and workforce accommodation may not be significantly impacted, but the city is not experiencing a severe supply squeeze either.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.3%. This indicates a relatively stable housing market, where homes are not selling extremely quickly, but still at a moderate pace. For workers relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, but not overly competitive, making it easier to find a home.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 98th. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may not be as well-suited for industries that rely heavily on industrial or logistics workers.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the city's moderate wage growth and relatively stable labor force growth rate may require businesses to be strategic in their hiring and talent attraction efforts, as the labor market is not exceptionally loose or tight.

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

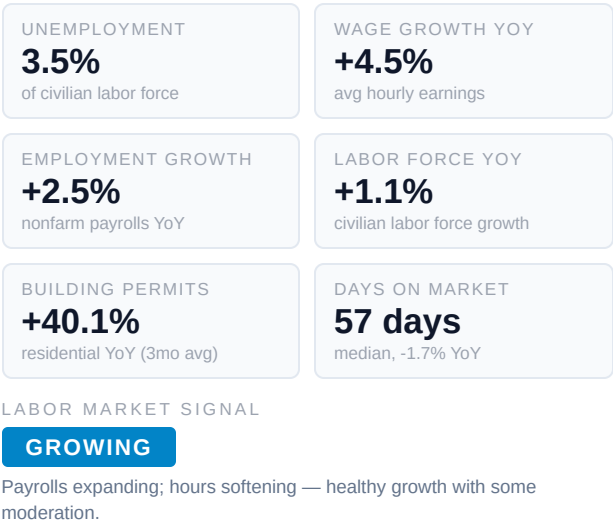
72.2th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 72.2th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 90th percentile, and its strong office economy, ranking in the 92nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 2.49% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.398% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 2.49% employment growth rate and a -0.398% deviation in weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours than trend, suggesting a healthy and sustainable labor market. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate, as it indicates a strong and growing workforce. The labor demand composite score of 7.39 further reinforces this, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 3.50%, which is in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is strong, which can be beneficial for businesses.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Salt Lake City-Murray is 4.49%, which is above average, ranking in the 64th percentile. This indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. The moderate wage growth suggests that businesses can expect to pay more for labor, but the increase is not excessive.

Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living score in the 37th percentile, with a PSF of \$263/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$39.26/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.70. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 0.8% year-over-year increase in PSF further reinforces this, suggesting that the city's affordability is decreasing.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is growing at a rate of 1.13% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 86th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire and grow. The

increasing labor force suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray has increased by 40.08% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 88th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for businesses, as it indicates that the city is investing in its infrastructure and preparing for growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Salt Lake City-Murray is 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%. This indicates that the housing market is relatively competitive, with homes selling quickly. However, the decrease in days on market suggests that the market is still accessible for relocating workers, and businesses can expect a relatively smooth transition for new employees.

Office Economy

Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 92nd percentile, with a share of 4.32 out of 5. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized workers. However, the city may be less suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a growing workforce. However, the relatively high cost of living and tight labor market may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these constraints when considering relocation or expansion in this city. Overall, the city's strong economic character and growing infrastructure make it an attractive location for businesses, but careful planning and strategic decision-making are necessary to navigate its competitive labor market.

St. Louis

St. Louis

A+

EXCELLENT

71.6th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		78
Unemployment 20% weight		82
Wage Growth 15% weight		48
Cost of Living 12% weight		96
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		70
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		70
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		54

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.8%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.5% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +18.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 45 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 71.6th percentile, ranking it among the top metros in the US. The city's economic character is defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 6.44, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the 96th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand is driven by a +0.68% employment growth rate and a +1.193% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of +0.68% employment growth and +1.193% hours deviation signals genuine demand expansion in St. Louis, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This suggests a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.44, ranked in the 78th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.80%, ranking in the 82nd percentile, which indicates a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in St. Louis is +3.51%, ranked in the 48th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and workers have reasonable purchasing power. However, the moderate wage growth may not be sufficient to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF of \$164/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$38.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.30, ranked in the 96th percentile. This means that the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a high quality of life without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.54% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This suggests that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and expand operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis has increased by +18.86% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers, making it an

attractive location for businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 45 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranked in the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable days on market suggests a balanced market.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional talent pool ranked in the 54th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of specialized workers. The city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and expanding workforce supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to grow and expand. However, the city's moderate wage growth and relatively tight labor market may pose challenges for businesses trying to hire and retain top talent, and decision-makers should factor in these constraints when considering St. Louis as a potential location.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

71.4th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		32
25% weight		
Unemployment		94
20% weight		
Wage Growth		98
15% weight		
Cost of Living		90
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		54
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		76
10% weight		
Days on Market		98
5% weight		
Office Economy		42
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +8.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +24.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 42 days median, +13.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking at the 71.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.70% and high wage growth of 8.11% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a tight labor market with strong demand for workers.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is 0.31% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by 0.000%, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.73, which ranks below average at the 32nd percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend despite job growth. The labor market is not experiencing a survivor squeeze, as job growth is present, albeit slow.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.70%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means there is little slack in the market, making it challenging for businesses to hire new workers. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is 8.11% year-over-year, ranking at the 98th percentile, which is exceptionally high. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also increases worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in higher labor costs when considering operations in this city.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living score that ranks at the 90th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$191/sqft to \$36.31/hr, or 5.26. The city's PSF is decreasing by 0.5% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to peers. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of -0.21% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This indicates a slight contraction in the labor force supply, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring capacity in the future.

Building Permits

Building permits in Cincinnati are increasing by 24.76% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and accommodation for the workforce, reducing potential future constraints on hiring.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cincinnati is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.5%, ranking at the 98th percentile. This slower market means homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing, which can be beneficial for businesses attracting talent.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share ranks at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy but may not be the best fit for those requiring a deeply specialized knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance hubs.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of low unemployment, high wage growth, and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for hiring challenges due to the tight labor market and slightly contracting labor force supply, which may require strategic workforce planning and compensation strategies.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

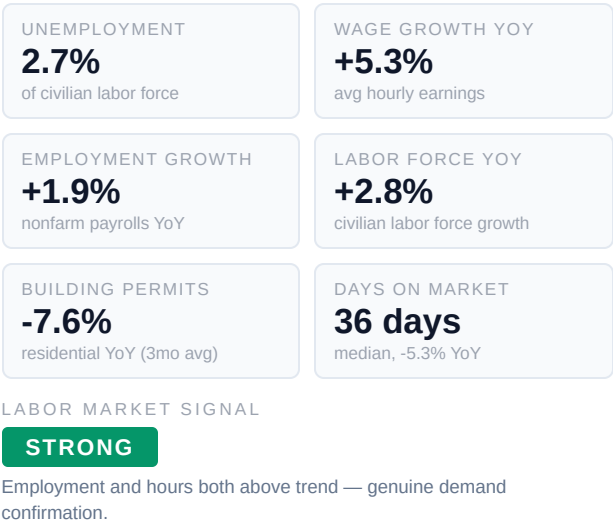
70.5th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 70.5th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score in the 86th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile. The combination of strong employment growth and low unemployment suggests a highly competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate of +1.88% year-over-year, combined with a +0.025% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This indicates that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting that businesses are not only hiring but also utilizing their workforce more intensively. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is extremely low, ranking in the 98th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent. As a result, wage pressure is likely to be high in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.30% is above average, ranking in the 74th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for rising labor costs when considering operations in this area.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$251/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$40.19/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.25, ranks in the 33rd percentile, indicating that it is below average in terms of affordability. However, the PSF is increasing by 3.3% year-over-year, which may erode affordability over time. This suggests that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to affordability, and businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests that there will be a growing pool of potential workers to draw from. However, the tight labor market may still pose challenges in finding qualified candidates.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -7.56%, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. Businesses should factor in the potential for rising housing costs and reduced affordability when considering long-term operations in the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -5.3%, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating a very competitive and fast-paced housing market. This suggests that workers relocating to the city may face challenges in finding and securing housing, which could impact their decision to move to the area.

Office Economy

The city's office economy, with a composite score ranking in the 26th percentile, indicates a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city may be better suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on specialized office or professional workers, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors may find it more challenging to attract and retain top talent in this market.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive and growing labor market, with strong demand and low unemployment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for rising labor costs and reduced affordability due to the tightening housing supply and increasing PSF. Businesses should carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location for operations.

Kansas City

Kansas City

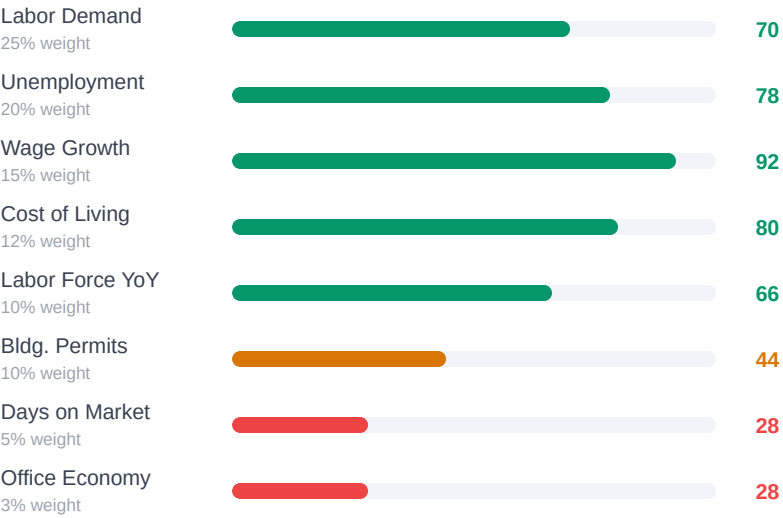
A+

EXCELLENT

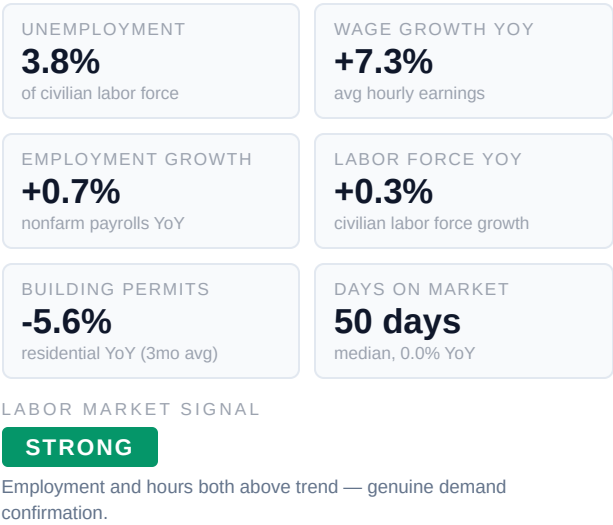
69.7th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 69.7th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 5.99, and its top-tier wage growth of 7.35% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate of 0.73% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of 0.665% above its own trend, indicates genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked increasing above the trend line. As a result, businesses can expect to find a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.80% is relatively low, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.35%, Kansas City is experiencing rapid labor cost increases, ranking in the 92nd percentile. This fast wage growth is a double-edged sword, as it increases labor costs for employers but also boosts worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses should factor in rising labor costs, while also considering the benefits of a workforce with increasing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living, with a PSF of \$196/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.39, ranks in the 80th percentile, indicating a relatively affordable city. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums. As a result, businesses can leverage the city's affordability to attract and retain top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force is growing at a rate of 0.34% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is modest, it suggests that the labor pool is not contracting, providing a stable foundation for hiring. As a result, businesses can expect to find a steady supply of workers, although growth may be limited.

Building Permits

Kansas City's building permits have decreased by 5.58% year-over-year, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits may signal future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation. As a result,

businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with no year-over-year change, ranking in the 28th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. As a result, businesses may need to provide relocation assistance or consider the potential impact on employee retention.

Office Economy

Kansas City's office economy, with a professional worker share ranking in the 28th percentile, indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors. While the city may not be the best fit for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, it may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements. As a result, businesses should carefully consider their specific talent needs when evaluating Kansas City as a potential location.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a strong labor market, rapid wage growth, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the city's tightening housing supply, as indicated by the decline in building permits, poses a significant risk to long-term workforce accommodation and affordability. As a result, decision-makers should carefully weigh the benefits of Kansas City's thriving job market against the potential challenges of a constrained housing market.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A

VERY GOOD

66.9th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		96
Unemployment 20% weight		80
Wage Growth 15% weight		62
Cost of Living 12% weight		74
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		40
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		12
Days on Market 5% weight		20
Office Economy 3% weight		86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.7% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -23.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 61 days median, +7.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring 96th percentile in labor demand composite and 86th percentile in office/professional worker share. The labor demand composite score of 7.82, driven by a 1.54% employment growth rate and a 1.361% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a strong and growing economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.54% and weekly hours deviation of 1.361% above trend indicate a labor market with genuine demand expansion, where jobs are being added and hours are increasing, signaling a healthy and growing economy. This combination is a strong indicator of a city where businesses can find the talent they need to expand. The labor demand composite score of 7.82 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking in the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available talent, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.22% is above average, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating a moderate to fast pace of wage increases. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but workers are also seeing an increase in their purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 74th, and a PSF to earnings ratio of \$218/sqft to \$38.91/hr, or 5.60. The fact that PSF is falling by 0.9% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.70% year-over-year, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This implies that hiring capacity may be constrained, and businesses may need to consider strategies to attract talent from other areas. The declining labor force growth rate may also signal a structural headwind for hiring.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -23.67%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The decline in building permits may also lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.0%, ranking in the 20th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing. The rising days on market may signal a normalization of the market, but the current pace still favors sellers.

Office Economy

The office economy in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is deep and talented, with an 86th percentile rank in terms of professional and office worker share. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized talent. On the other hand, the city may be less suitable for businesses with primarily industrial or logistics-based operations.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy, with a deep professional talent pool and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability, potentially impacting the city's attractiveness to talent and its overall competitiveness.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

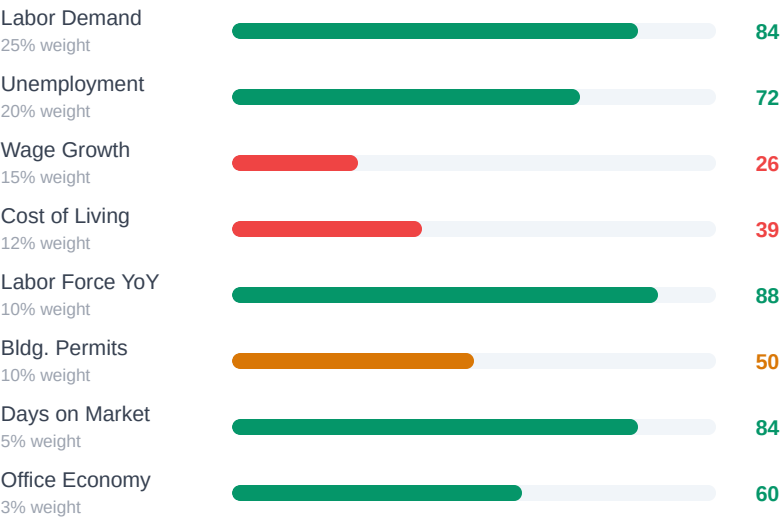
A

VERY GOOD

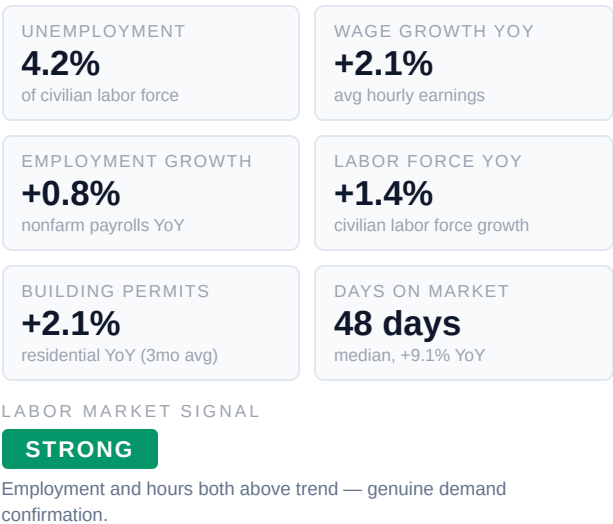
63.8th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and labor force growth, which stand at 84th and 88th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.76, combining a +0.83% employment growth rate and a +1.300% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its labor force growth, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.83% and weekly hours deviation of +1.300% from its own trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the trend, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.76 further reinforces this, placing it in the top tier at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.20% places the city above average, at the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there is less slack in the labor market, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, it also suggests a strong local economy with fewer workers seeking employment.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.14%, the city experiences below-average wage increases, ranking at the 26th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising too rapidly, but it also implies that workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power. The slower wage growth could be a mixed blessing for businesses, offering a relatively stable cost environment but potentially weaker worker bargaining power.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Philadelphia, with a PSF of \$228/sqft and hourly earnings of \$32.59, resulting in a ratio of 7.00, is below average, ranking at the 39th percentile. However, considering the inversion, this means the city is less affordable than its percentile rank might suggest, as a higher percentile score indicates more affordability. The city's affordability, or lack thereof, could impact talent attraction, as higher costs might require wage premiums to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.42% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate, placing the city in the top tier at the 88th percentile, suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is strong, with a growing pool of potential workers. This is a significant advantage for companies looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +2.10%, which is near the median, indicating a modest expansion in housing supply. This growth suggests that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and easier accommodation for the workforce. However, the near-median performance might not be enough to keep pace with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.1%, placing the city in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This longer days on market suggests a slower, more buyer-friendly market, which could make it easier for relocating workers to find housing. The rising DOM in a strong job market indicates a healthy normalization rather than demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.86, placing the city at the 60th percentile, Philadelphia has a deep enough professional talent pool to support businesses, particularly those in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. This makes the city well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but less ideal for industries requiring large industrial or logistics workforces.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively tight labor market and its potential to drive up wages, coupled with the city's below-average affordability, which might necessitate wage premiums to attract talent.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

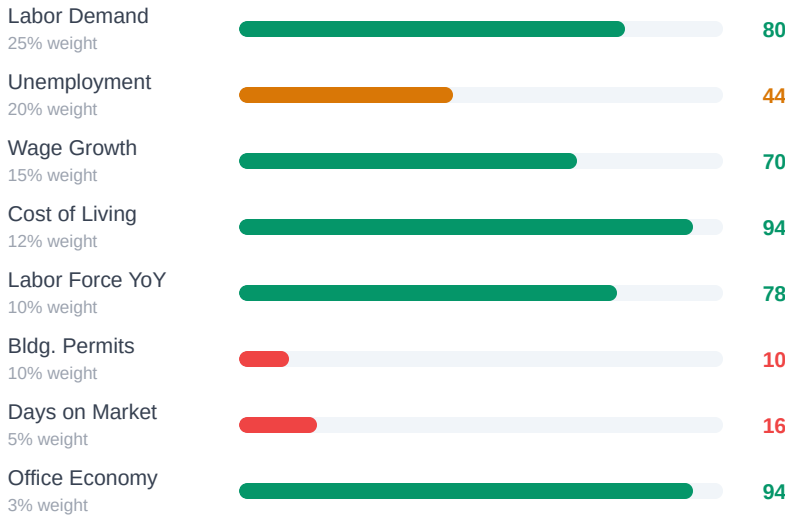
A-

GOOD

63.0th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-29.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

73 days

median, +1.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 63.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 80th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 94th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a thriving job market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has seen employment growth of +1.16% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of +0.667% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth where hours are running above trend, suggesting that businesses are not only hiring but also increasing the workload for existing employees. This is a positive indicator for companies looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos stands at 4.00%, placing it near the median at the 44th percentile. This rate suggests that the job market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, it also implies that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is +5.08%, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This indicates a moderate to fast pace of wage growth, which could lead to rising labor costs for employers. On the other hand, it also suggests good worker purchasing power, potentially benefiting local businesses through increased consumer spending.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$231/sqft to \$37.93/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of -8.0% in PSF, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is highly affordable, ranked at the 94th percentile. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can attract and retain workers without needing to offer substantial wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area has grown by +0.80% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply is a positive indicator for businesses, as it suggests that the pool of potential workers is increasing, making it easier to find and hire talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -29.04%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This significant decrease in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos are currently sitting on the market for a median of 73 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.4%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could be seen as more accessible for workers relocating to the area, as they have more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is significant, with the city ranking at the 94th percentile. This deep talent pool makes Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable living costs, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in residential building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and retaining workers.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

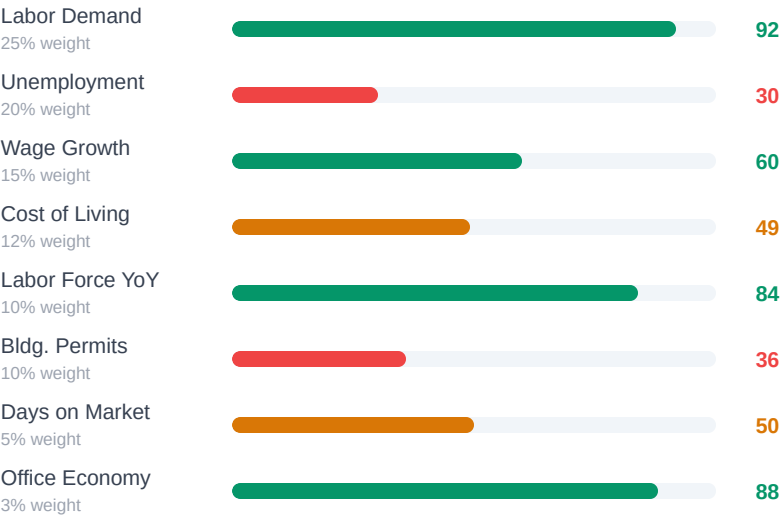
A-

GOOD

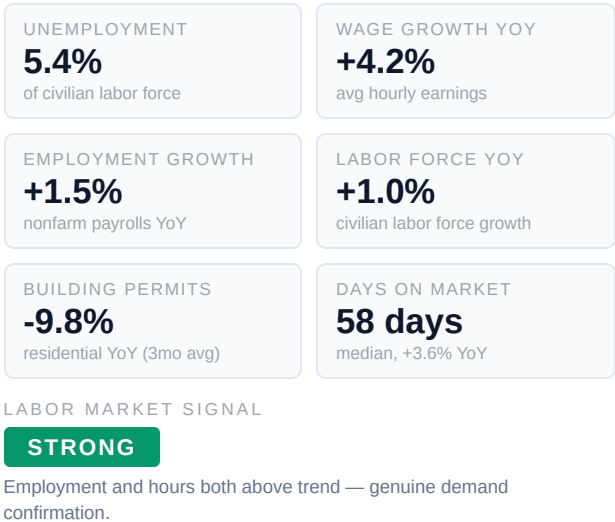
61.0th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 61.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score ranking in the 92nd percentile, and its above-average wage growth, at 4.21% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a thriving job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has seen employment growth of 1.46% year-over-year, combined with a 1.098% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is experiencing real demand for workers. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is 5.40%, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, as there is a larger pool of available labor. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is 4.21%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering operations in this area.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is near the median, with a percentile rank of 49th, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$261/sqft to \$33.35/hr, or 7.83. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is growing at a rate of 0.98% year-over-year, ranking in the 84th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire workers. A growing labor force can provide a larger pool of potential employees, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has decreased by 9.84% year-over-year, ranking in the 36th percentile. This signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. This is a potential concern for businesses that may need to attract workers from other areas.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.6%. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. However, the rising days on market could signal a healthy normalization of the market, making it slightly easier for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 88th. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with growing demand and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more difficult to attract workers from other areas.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.7th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		82
Unemployment 20% weight		28
Wage Growth 15% weight		54
Cost of Living 12% weight		86
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		76
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		24
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.6%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +1.0%	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -13.4%	DAYS ON MARKET 58 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 86th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.00% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.903% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.00% employment growth rate and a 0.903% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.60 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the top tier.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington stands at 4.60%, which ranks below average at the 28th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some level of competition for talent, which could lead to moderate wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 4.03%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable rate. For workers, this translates into rising purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living score ranked at the 86th percentile, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is considered highly affordable relative to its peers. The city's price per square foot of \$199, which has decreased by 2.0% year-over-year, combined with an average hourly wage of \$38.10, results in a favorable ratio of 5.22. This affordability advantage can attract talent without necessitating significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area is growing at a rate of 0.79% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 76th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -13.44%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This decline suggests that the housing supply is not expanding as quickly as demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 58 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranked below average at the 28th percentile, may pose challenges for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly, indicating a competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in the metro area is significant, with a composite score ranking at the 94th percentile. This deep talent pool makes Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington particularly well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a highly affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential future affordability issue signaled by the decline in residential building permits, which could impact workforce accommodation and talent attraction over time.

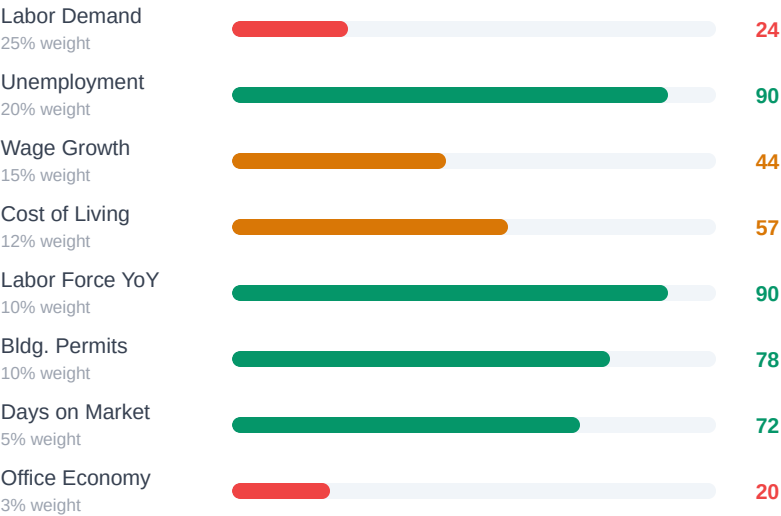
Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.5th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.5th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.70% and its strong labor force growth of +1.61% YoY. These metrics signal a tight labor market with expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.05% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.173% from the city's own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 4.06 ranks below average at the 24th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.70%, ranking at the 90th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate implies a seller's market for labor.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is +3.33% YoY, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. The wage growth rate is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.44/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.14, ranks near the median at the 57th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The stable YoY change in PSF (+0.0%) contributes to the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +1.61% YoY, ranking at the 90th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive environment for hiring and business growth. The increasing labor force can help meet the demands of growing businesses.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh is increasing by +25.84% YoY, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rising permits suggest a

positive outlook for future housing availability.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 53 days, with a YoY increase of +6.0%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, expanding workforce supply, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited depth in professional and office talent, which may hinder the growth of certain types of businesses.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.2th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		72
Unemployment 20% weight		12
Wage Growth 15% weight		90
Cost of Living 12% weight		71
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		60
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		28
Days on Market 5% weight		64
Office Economy 3% weight		90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.8%	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -11.7%	DAYS ON MARKET 75 days median, -2.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 72nd percentile, and its top-tier wage growth of 6.12% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a robust job market and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 0.80% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.783% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.20 further reinforces this assessment, placing the city in the 72nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.70%, ranking it in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire in this city, as there is a larger pool of available workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to cities with tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.12%, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the 90th percentile. This rapid wage growth will lead to rising labor costs for employers but will also increase worker purchasing power, benefiting the local economy. Businesses should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in this city.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score in the 71st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$223/sqft to \$34.05/hr, or 6.55. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.6% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 0.22% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. While this growth is positive, its slow pace may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the long term, as the labor pool is not expanding rapidly.

Building Permits

The city has seen a year-over-year decline in building permits of 11.73%, ranking it in the 28th percentile. This decrease suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend may signal a potential risk for businesses relying on a readily available and affordable housing stock for their employees.

Days on Market

Homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford are currently sitting on the market for a median of 75 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, combined with the decrease in days on market, indicates a competitive housing market that may be challenging for relocating workers. However, the market is not extremely heated, suggesting some accessibility for those looking to move to the area.

Office Economy

With an office economy score ranking it in the 90th percentile, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city particularly well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

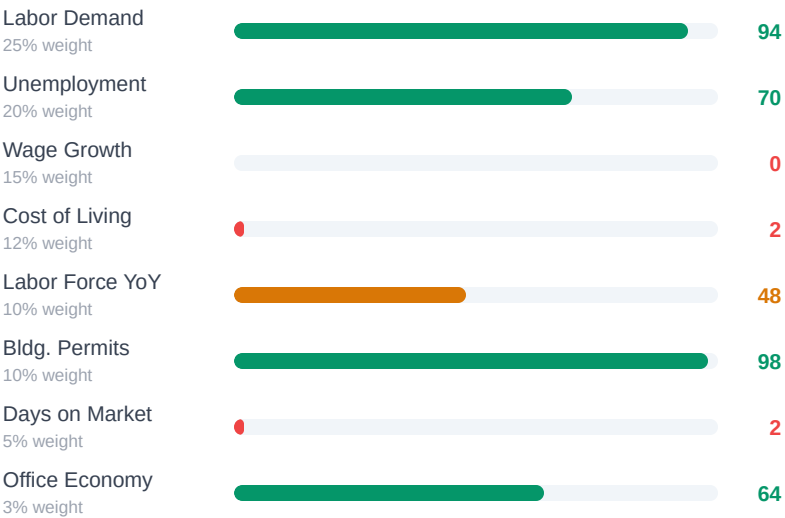
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AVERAGE

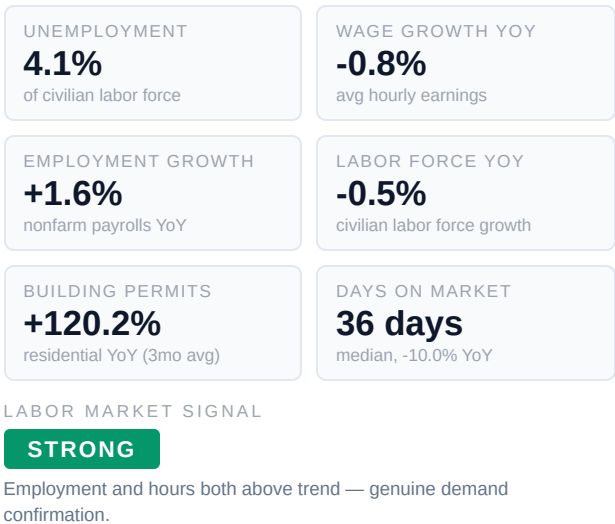
54.4th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and building permits growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.81, which combines a 1.59% employment growth rate and a 1.289% weekly hours deviation above trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. The unemployment rate and cost of living metrics also play a significant role in defining the city's economic character, with an unemployment rate of 4.10% and a cost of living ratio of 15.01.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a labor demand composite score of 7.81, driven by a 1.59% employment growth rate and a 1.289% weekly hours deviation above trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This suggests a strong and growing economy, with businesses likely to face competition for talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 4.10%, ranking in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available to fill open positions. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is -0.78%, ranking in the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also means that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. This could impact the local consumer demand and overall economic growth.

Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living ratio of 15.01, with a PSF of \$811/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$54.03/hr, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is decreasing by 1.3% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is growing at a rate of -0.48% year-over-year, ranking near the median. This contraction in labor force supply may create structural headwinds for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from other areas.

Building Permits

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has seen a 120.21% year-over-year increase in building permits, ranking in the top tier. This rapid growth in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 10.0%. This fast-paced market, ranking in the bottom tier, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are selling quickly. This could impact the attractiveness of the area for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 2.92, ranking in the 64th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and knowledgeable workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and expanding housing supply, driven by rapid growth in building permits. However, the city's high cost of living and stagnant wage growth pose significant risks, as businesses may struggle to attract and retain talent without offering competitive wages and benefits. Ultimately, decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering the area for relocation or expansion.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B

AVERAGE

54.0th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		18
25% weight		
Unemployment		56
20% weight		
Wage Growth		88
15% weight		
Cost of Living		88
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		56
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		32
10% weight		
Days on Market		94
5% weight		
Office Economy		36
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.2% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -10.3% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 44 days median, +12.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and affordable cost of living, scoring 88th percentile in both metrics, with a wage growth rate of +5.99% and a cost of living ratio of \$214/sqft vs \$37.96/hr. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a competitive labor market with rising earnings and a relatively low cost of living. Specifically, the cost of living is becoming more affordable, with PSF falling by 3.2% YoY.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.47% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.175% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.64, which ranks in the bottom tier at 18th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a slowdown in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face less competition for labor, but also a less dynamic job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.20%, ranking near the median at 56th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it moderately easy to hire workers, without excessive wage pressure. However, the market is not so loose that it would lead to a significant surplus of available labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +5.99%, ranking in the top tier at 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees are seeing significant increases in their earnings. However, this may put pressure on businesses to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living ratio of \$214/sqft vs \$37.96/hr, with PSF falling by 3.2% YoY, resulting in a top-tier percentile rank of 88th, making it more affordable relative to peers. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a higher standard of living without requiring wage premiums. The falling PSF is a key driver of this affordability, making the city an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of -0.04% YoY, ranking near the median at 56th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of available workers is not expanding, which may pose a structural

headwind for hiring in the long term. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in workforce development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is decreasing by -10.35% YoY, ranking below average at 32nd percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This could lead to increased competition for available housing and higher costs for workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 44 days, with a YoY increase of +12.8%, resulting in a top-tier percentile rank of 94th. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer, indicating a slower and more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to this city, this means that they may have more time to find a home and negotiate a better price, making the city a more accessible location.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy percentile rank of 36th, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more attractive to businesses that require a more general workforce or have a strong logistics or industrial component.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a competitive labor market with rising earnings and a relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to increased competition for available housing and higher costs for workers, potentially offsetting the city's affordability advantages.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

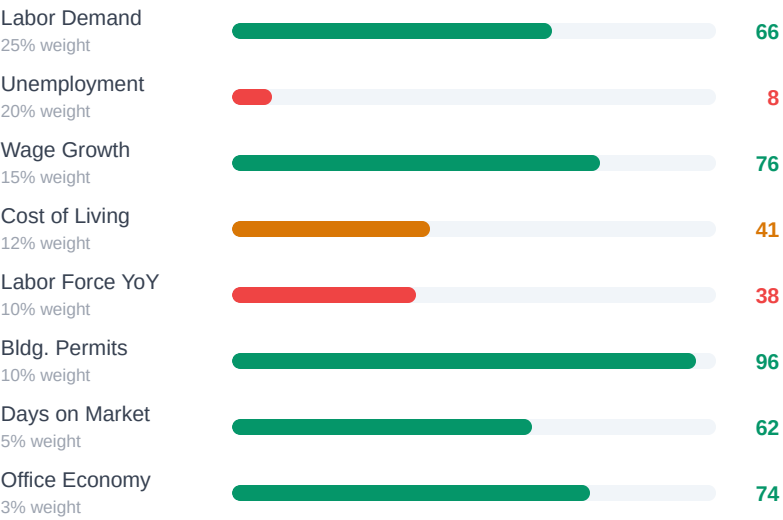
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AVERAGE

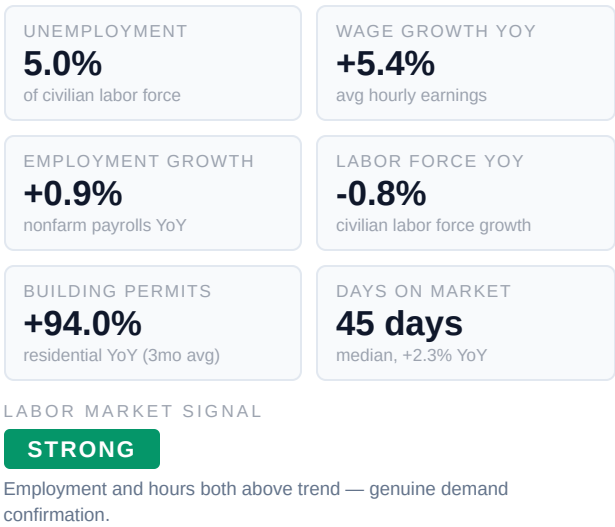
53.1th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, notably a +0.88% employment growth rate and +5.44% year-over-year wage growth. These metrics suggest a city with expanding job opportunities and increasing labor costs. The labor demand composite score of 5.94, combining employment growth and hours worked above trend, indicates genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue area exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.94, with employment growth of +0.88% year-over-year and weekly hours deviating +0.406% from its own 12-month baseline, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than typical, suggesting a strong and growing labor market. The scenario points to a healthy job market where hours above trend accompany job growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue stands at 5.00%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate translates to higher competition for available workers and potential upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, being competitive with salary and benefits will be crucial.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +5.44%, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue experiences above-average wage increases, ranking in the 76th percentile. This fast wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, which is good for worker purchasing power but may strain business budgets. The strong wage growth environment indicates a competitive labor market where workers have bargaining power.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue, with a PSF of \$432/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$48.08, results in a ratio of 8.99, ranking near the median at the 41st percentile. This indicates that the city is neither extremely affordable nor overly expensive compared to its peers. The slight decrease in PSF (-1.8% YoY) relative to wages suggests a moderate affordability level, which can be a talent attraction advantage without necessitating significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has contracted by -0.77% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies or offer more competitive packages to attract talent in a shrinking labor market.

Building Permits

The city has seen a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of +93.96%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This surge in building permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rapid growth in permits is a positive indicator for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue currently sit on the market for a median of 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.3%. This moderate days on market, ranking in the 62nd percentile, suggests a relatively balanced market that is not overly competitive for buyers. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is accessible, with homes not selling extremely quickly, allowing for a more relaxed home search process.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share composite score of 3.08, ranking in the 74th percentile, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles but may be less ideal for those dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue offers a business environment characterized by strong labor demand, tight unemployment, and rising wages, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking a skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the shrinking labor force, which may necessitate innovative hiring strategies or competitive compensation packages to attract and retain talent in this market.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B

AVERAGE

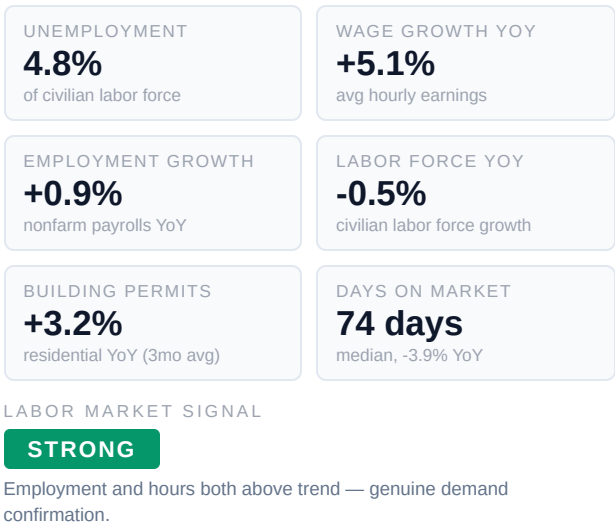
52.5th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its above-average labor demand and top-tier cost of living. The city's economic character is most defined by its 60th percentile labor demand composite score, which combines a +0.92% employment growth rate and a +0.120% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, and its 84th percentile cost of living score, indicating a highly affordable environment. This affordability is underscored by a PSF of \$233/sqft, which has decreased by 5.7% year-over-year, paired with an average hourly wage of \$37.29, resulting in a ratio of 6.25.

Labor Demand

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.71, placing it in the 60th percentile, driven by a +0.92% employment growth rate and a +0.120% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. The positive trend in both employment and hours worked suggests a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater stands at 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with significant competition for workers. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The low unemployment rate suggests that the local labor market has little slack, making it harder for companies to find and recruit talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area is +5.13%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, which is considered above average. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. As wages grow rapidly, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent, while workers benefit from increased disposable income.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living score in the 84th percentile, making it one of the more affordable cities relative to its peers. The decreasing PSF of \$233/sqft, down 5.7% year-over-year, compared to average hourly earnings of \$37.29, results in a favorable ratio of 6.25. This high affordability score means that the city has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring substantial wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has contracted by -0.50% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 44th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply suggests that the hiring capacity may be constrained, posing a structural challenge for businesses looking to expand their workforce. The shrinking labor pool could limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +3.19%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This moderate increase in building permits indicates that the housing supply is slowly expanding, which should help improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth over time. However, the pace of expansion may not be sufficient to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 74 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.9%, placing it in the 76th percentile. This relatively fast market, with homes selling quickly, may pose challenges for relocating workers, as they may face competition and pressure to make rapid purchasing decisions. The fast-paced housing market could be a consideration for businesses relocating employees to the area.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater places it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers but may be less ideal for those primarily involved in industrial or logistics sectors.

In conclusion, Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand, fast wage growth, and a highly affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent and business expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and the potential for hiring challenges due to the low unemployment rate and contracting labor force supply, which could limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth and require strategic workforce planning.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

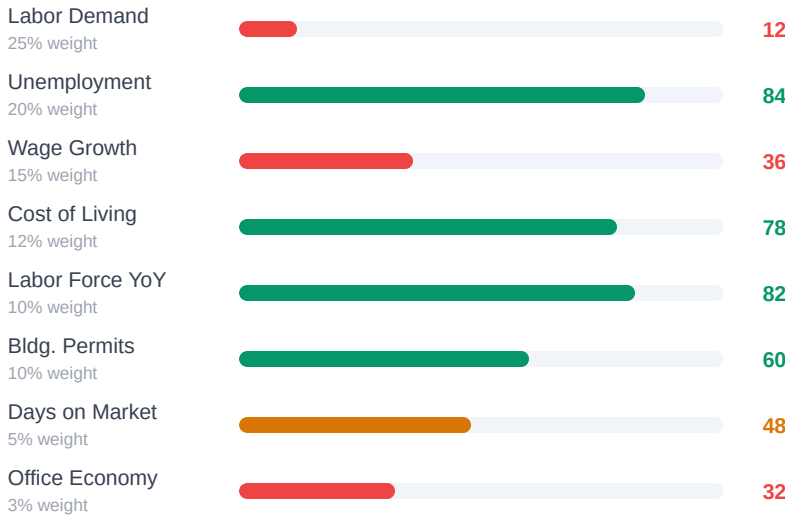
B

AVERAGE

52.1th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+7.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

59 days

median, +3.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 52.1th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a cost of living score that indicates relative affordability. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a tight labor market with moderate affordability. Specifically, the cost of living is characterized by a PSF of \$195/sqft, which has decreased by 0.5% YoY, combined with an hourly wage of \$37.62, resulting in a ratio of 5.18.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.46% YoY, while weekly hours are deviating 0.595% above the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a scenario where hours are increasing despite job losses, which suggests a survivor squeeze. This combination signals that the labor market is not expanding in terms of job numbers, but existing workers are taking on more hours. The labor demand composite score of 3.06 falls into the bottom tier, at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.20%, which ranks in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have significant bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Atlanta is +3.11% YoY, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile, indicating moderate wage increases. This level of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit at a moderate pace. The wage growth rate is not stagnant, but it is also not fast enough to significantly outpace the national average.

Cost of Living

Atlanta's cost of living score indicates that the city is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 78th, suggesting that it is more affordable than most of its peer cities. The PSF of \$195/sqft, which has decreased by 0.5% YoY, combined with an hourly wage of \$37.62, results in a ratio of 5.18, indicating a moderate cost burden. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor for businesses, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +0.88% YoY, which ranks in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is increasing, as more workers

are available to fill positions. The expanding labor pool is a positive sign for businesses looking to grow their workforce.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is increasing by +7.37% YoY, which ranks above average at the 60th percentile, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This increase in building permits suggests that the city's housing market is likely to become more affordable in the future, which can improve workforce accommodation and attraction. The growing housing supply can help mitigate potential labor shortages.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is 59 days, with a YoY increase of +3.5%, which ranks near the median at the 48th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely hot nor cold, which can make it accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Atlanta's professional and office worker share is ranked below average at the 32nd percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these sectors compared to other cities. This suggests that Atlanta may be less suited for businesses that require a large number of specialized tech, finance, or consulting roles, but could be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements. The city's economy is more diverse, with a smaller share of office-based jobs.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate affordability, and an expanding workforce supply, making it an attractive location for companies that can navigate the competitive hiring environment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for labor shortages and wage pressure due to the low unemployment rate, which may require businesses to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain talent.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

B

AVERAGE

52.0th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		46
Unemployment 20% weight		92
Wage Growth 15% weight		52
Cost of Living 12% weight		51
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		30
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		14
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.9% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -21.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 60 days median, +1.7% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking at the 52.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and a near-median labor demand composite score of 5.26. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, indicating a tight labor market with moderate job growth. Specifically, the unemployment rate and labor demand score suggest a city with genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Nashville is +0.65% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.047% from its own 12-month baseline, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing job growth with hours running above trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are absorbing additional workloads. The labor demand composite score of 5.26, ranking at the 46th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville is 3.10%, ranking at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This low unemployment rate means that the market has little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent in this competitive market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Nashville is +3.92%, ranking at the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing some improvement in their purchasing power. The moderate wage growth rate may help balance the tight labor market, but it still poses a cost consideration for businesses.

Cost of Living

Nashville has a cost of living score ranking at the 51st percentile, with a PSF of \$259/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.25. The city's cost of living is near the median, making it neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.1% year-over-year slightly improves the affordability. This near-median affordability means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but it does not provide a strong talent attraction advantage either.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville is growing at a rate of -0.95% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, posing a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. The shrinking labor pool may exacerbate the already tight labor market conditions.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Nashville is -21.89%, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This significant decrease in building permits signals a potential future supply squeeze, which could worsen affordability and make it more challenging for the workforce to find accommodation, ultimately affecting the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville is 60 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. For workers relocating to Nashville, this means that the housing market is somewhat more accessible than in faster-moving markets, but the rising days on market could signal a normalization of the market rather than a significant easing of competition.

Office Economy

Nashville has an office economy score ranking at the 78th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with moderate job growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it attractive for certain sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force and sharp decline in housing supply expansion, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and accommodating workers.

Columbus

Columbus

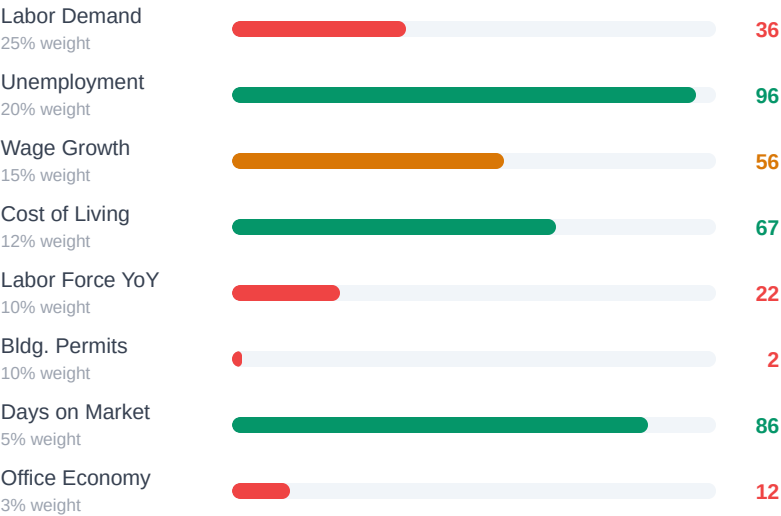
B

AVERAGE

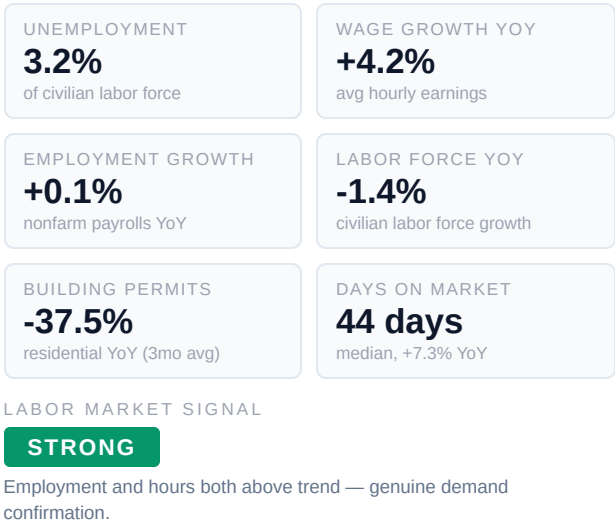
51.7th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 51.7th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and a labor demand composite score of 4.88, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate wage growth. Specifically, the combination of a +0.06% employment growth rate and +0.492% weekly hours deviation signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a slow one.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.06% year-over-year, accompanied by a +0.492% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination indicates a genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the city is experiencing a slow but steady increase in job creation and hours worked. However, the below-average labor demand composite score of 4.88 suggests that this growth is not as robust as in other cities.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.20%, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

Columbus experiences a year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.15%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in Columbus benefit from increasing purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$205/sqft to \$34.84/hr, Columbus ranks at the 67th percentile in terms of affordability, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year relative to wages enhances this affordability. This makes Columbus an attractive location for talent, as workers can enjoy a relatively low cost of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -1.35% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to compensate for this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Columbus has decreased by -37.46% year-over-year, ranking at the bottom tier of the 2nd percentile. This sharp decline in building permits signals a tightening of future housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for the workforce to find accommodation.

Days on Market

Homes in Columbus currently sit on the market for a median of 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.3%. This ranks at the 86th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to Columbus, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with less competition for homes compared to faster-moving markets.

Office Economy

Columbus has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking at the 12th percentile in terms of the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more appropriate for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and relatively high affordability. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force and sharply declining building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and accommodating workers.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

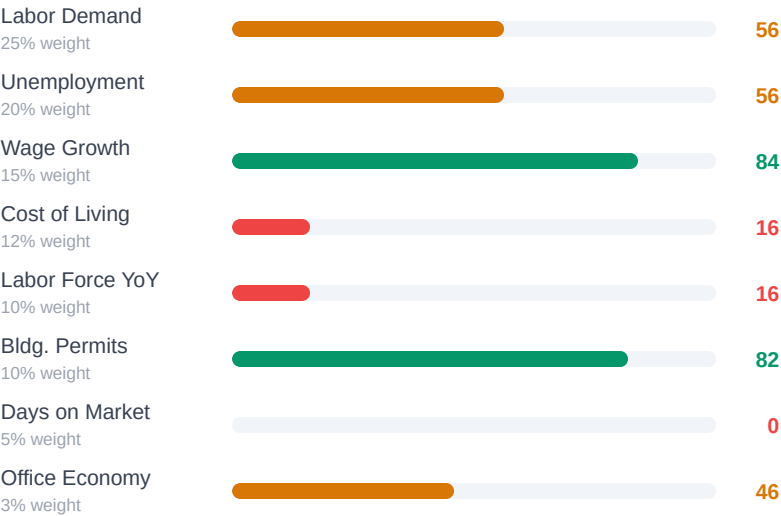
B

AVERAGE

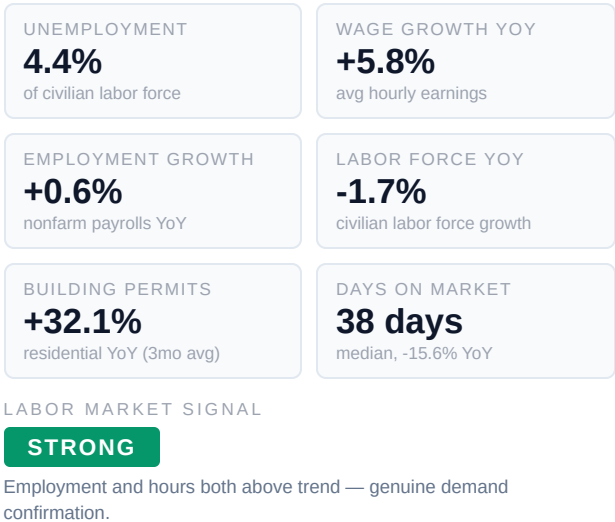
50.9th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 50.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 5.78% year-over-year and its bottom-tier cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 12.28, indicating a relatively expensive market. These metrics suggest a city with a high demand for labor but also significant cost pressures.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.56% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.469% above its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.55 places the city near the median, indicating a balanced labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 4.40%, which is near the median percentile rank of 56th. This rate suggests a relatively tight labor market, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 5.78%, placing it in the top tier of the 84th percentile. This rapid wage growth indicates a strong labor market with rising labor costs for employers. However, it also suggests good worker purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses through increased consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a cost of living percentile rank of 16th, indicating a relatively expensive market. The PSF to wages ratio is 12.28, with the PSF currently at \$619/sqft, which has decreased by 3.9% year-over-year. This affordability challenge may hinder talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has contracted by 1.71% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has experienced a 32.14% year-over-year increase in building permits, placing it in the top tier of the 82nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is currently 38 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 15.6%. This rapid sales pace indicates a competitive market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an office economy percentile rank of 46th, indicating a moderately deep professional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors but may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with high wage growth and an expanding housing supply, but it also presents significant cost pressures and a competitive housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially eroding profit margins.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

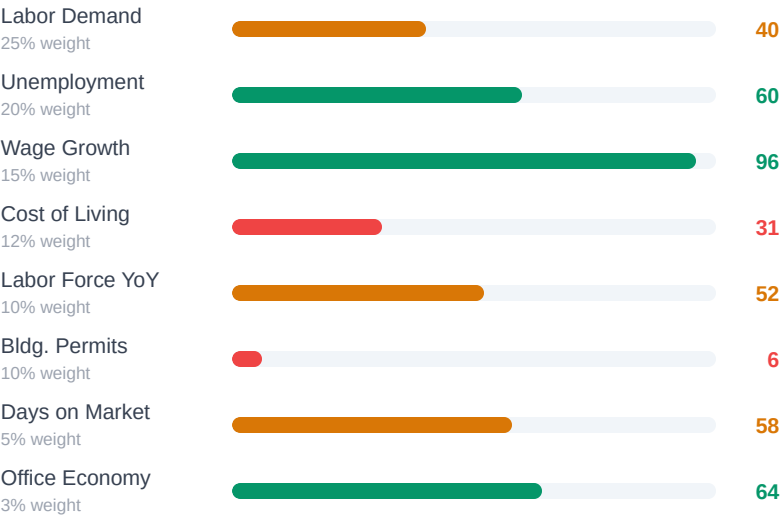
B

AVERAGE

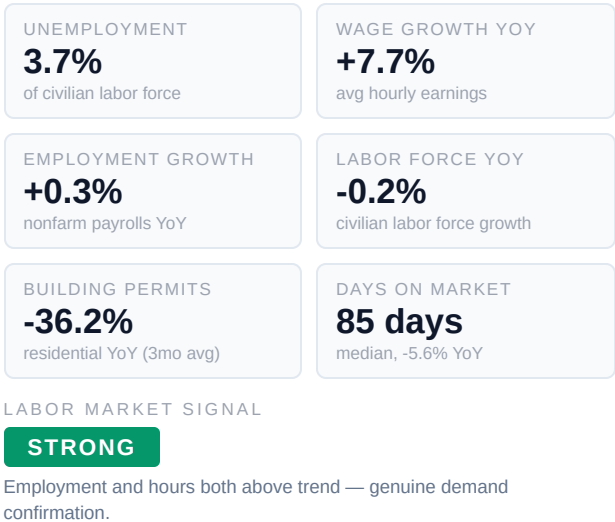
50.7th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and above-average office economy. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 7.68% year-over-year and its above-average share of professional and office workers, at 64th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong knowledge economy and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.35% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.285% above its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score at the 40th percentile. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. The city's labor market is growing, but not at a rate that would indicate a significant surge in hiring activity.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.70%, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.68%, placing it at the 96th percentile, indicating fast and rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees' earnings are increasing rapidly. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses, as labor costs are rising quickly.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score at the 31st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$355/sqft to \$35.24/hr, or 10.07, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of 0.8%. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive, ranking below average in terms of affordability. The low affordability score may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.22% year-over-year, ranking at the 52nd percentile, indicating a slight contraction in the labor force supply. This implies that the hiring capacity may be limited, as the pool of available workers is not expanding. Businesses may need to consider this constraint when planning their hiring strategies.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -36.23%, ranking at the 6th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of the housing supply. This suggests that the city's future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 5.6%, ranking at the 58th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market, where homes are selling fairly quickly. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be challenging to navigate, with homes selling rapidly.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant workforces.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a strong knowledge economy with rising labor costs and a relatively tight labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited affordability and tightening housing supply, which may pose challenges for attracting and retaining talent without offering significant wage premiums.

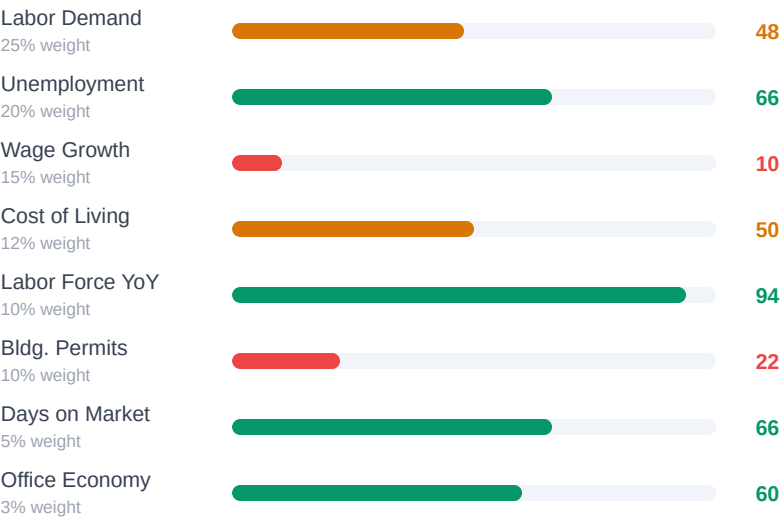
Cleveland

Cleveland

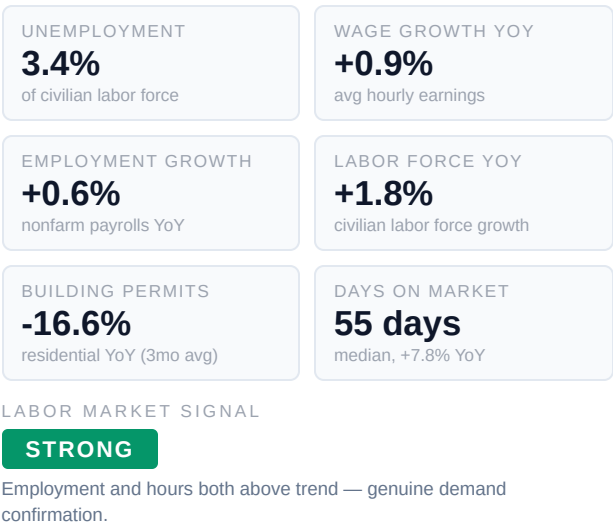
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.4th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 49.4th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its near-median labor demand and above-average unemployment rate, which are the two metrics that most define its current economic character, with employment growth at +0.57% and an unemployment rate of 3.40%. The city's labor market is further influenced by its low wage growth and relatively stable cost of living. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 5.27 and the unemployment rate percentile of 66th are key indicators of the city's economic state.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.57% and weekly hours deviation of +0.170% from the city's own trend suggest a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a moderate pace. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing job growth, and the increase in hours worked suggests that the existing workforce is being utilized more intensively. The labor demand composite score of 5.27, ranking at the 48th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.40% ranks at the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.88% is relatively low, ranking at the 10th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power and may not see significant increases in their purchasing power. This could impact the overall attractiveness of the city to workers and businesses alike.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.17, based on \$143/sqft and \$34.26/hr, and a percentile rank of 50th, Cleveland is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is increasing by 13.5% YoY while wages are growing slowly may put upward pressure on this ratio in the future. This neutral cost of living situation means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but it also does not provide a strong competitive advantage in terms of affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, ranking at the 94th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force provides a larger pool of

potential employees, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -16.61%, ranking at the 22nd percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in building permits may signal a potential supply squeeze, making it more difficult for workers to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.8%. This ranks at the 66th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to Cleveland, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, giving them more time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share of 2.86 and a percentile rank of 60th, Cleveland has a relatively deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city more suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a growing labor force and a relatively stable cost of living, but its slow wage growth and tightening housing supply are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges due to the decline in building permits, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

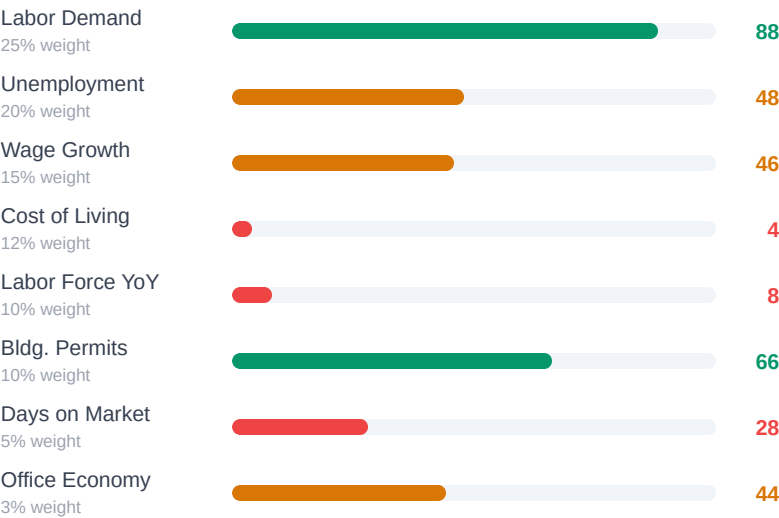
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

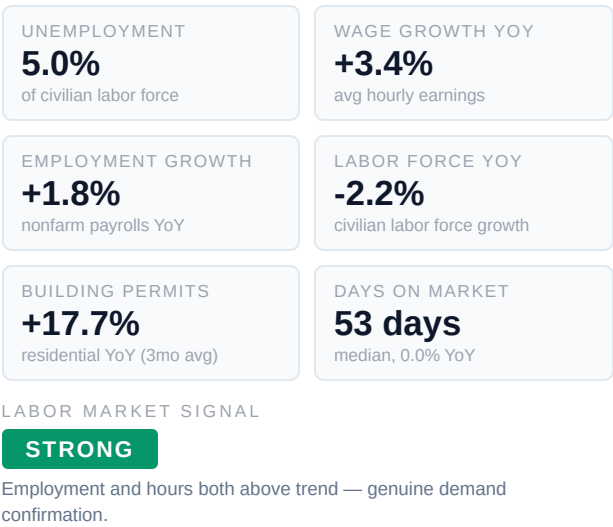
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.1th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, and its high cost of living, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$652/sqft to \$41.54/hr, or 15.70. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's current economic landscape, with employment growth at 1.83% and weekly hours 0.151% above trend.

Labor Demand

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.83% and weekly hours 0.151% above its own 12-month baseline, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above trend, suggesting that businesses are actively hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 7.01 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 5.00%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire workers compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a significant surplus of available workers, and businesses may still face some competition for top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 3.39%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. Workers in the area are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a cost of living ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$652/sqft to \$41.54/hr, or 15.70. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.1% year-over-year provides some relief, but the overall cost of living remains a significant concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is contracting at a rate of -2.18% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire workers, as the available pool of talent is shrinking.

Building Permits

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has experienced a 17.69% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it may help to alleviate some of the pressure on the local housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 53 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the market is competitive, making it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing options.

Office Economy

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an office economy ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.32 out of 5. This suggests that the city has a moderate depth of professional talent, making it suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but potentially less attractive for those requiring a more specialized or industrial workforce.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a growing housing supply, but it also presents significant challenges, particularly in terms of its high cost of living and shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain top talent.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

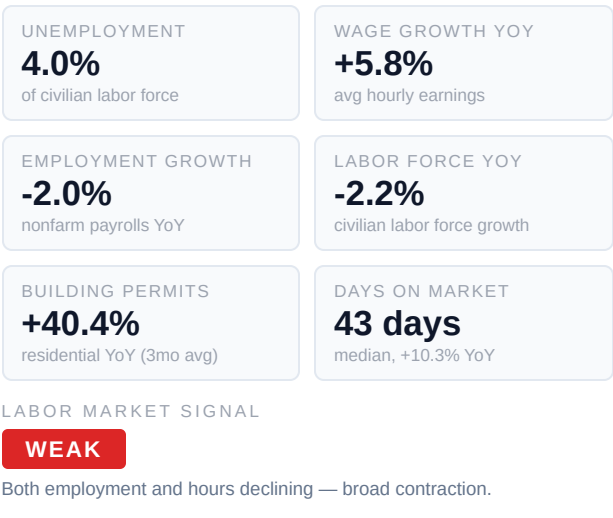
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
48.3th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth of 5.85% year-over-year and its low labor demand composite score of 1.56, indicating a challenging job market. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with rising labor costs but limited job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -1.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.606% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.00%, ranking it at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring and retaining talent, as the pool of available workers is smaller than in other cities. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.85%, ranking it at the 86th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising rapidly, while workers are experiencing increased purchasing power. Businesses should factor in the potential for rising labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living percentile rank of 69th, with a PSF of \$298/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.93/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.49. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF (-2.3% YoY) contributing to its high affordability score. This makes it an attractive location for businesses looking to recruit talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding their workforce, as the supply of available workers is declining.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 40.37% year-over-year, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for relocating workers in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%, ranking it at the 90th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be normalizing after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has an office economy percentile rank of 32nd, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on a strong knowledge economy.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and relatively affordable living costs, making it an attractive location for talent recruitment. However, the city's low labor demand and contracting labor force pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand their workforce, and decision-makers should carefully consider these constraints when evaluating this location.

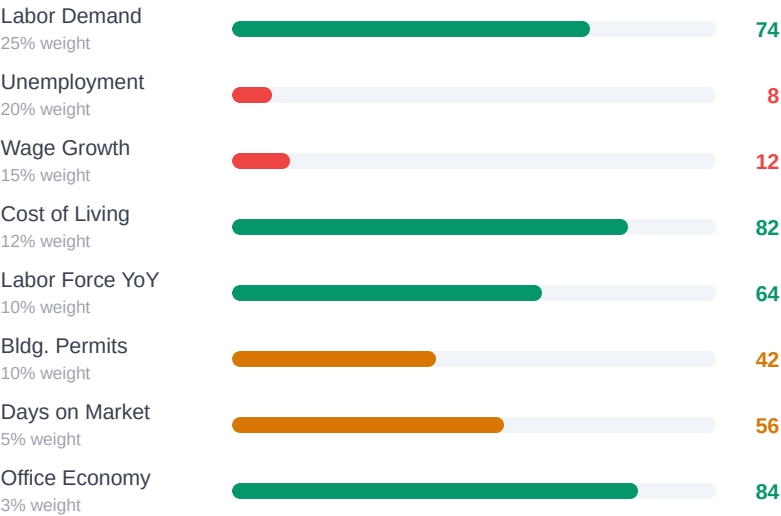
Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

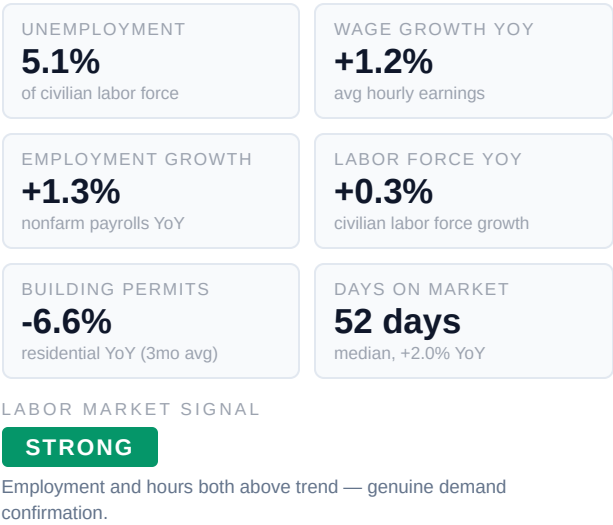
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.6th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 47.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 74th percentile, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking in the 82nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.30% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 0.091% above the city's own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 6.21 is in the 74th percentile, indicating a strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 5.10%, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.21%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a cost of living score in the 82nd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$169/sqft to \$36.92/hr, or 4.58. The fact that the PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This high affordability score is a talent attraction advantage, as workers can be drawn to the area without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of 0.28% year-over-year, ranking in the 64th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. However, the growth rate is relatively modest, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid hiring.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is falling by 6.61% year-over-year, ranking in the 42nd percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limitations on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%. This relatively moderate days on market suggests a balanced market that is neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is ranked in the 84th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth, which may limit worker purchasing power and local consumer demand, potentially impacting businesses that rely on a strong local economy.

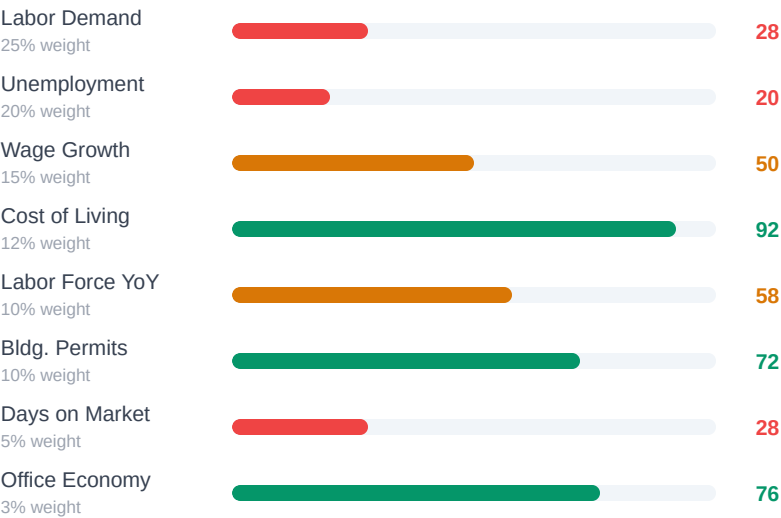
San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

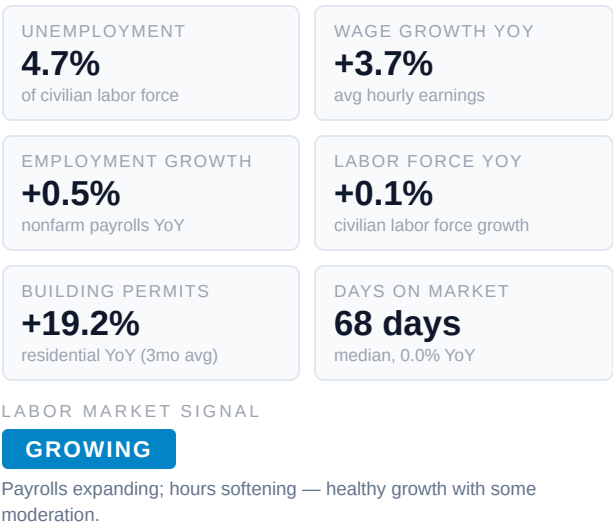
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.2th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 46.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.36, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 92nd percentile. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are the most critical in understanding the city's current economic situation, with employment growth at 0.51% and a cost of living ratio of \$170/sqft to \$33.17/hr.

Labor Demand

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.51% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.651% from its own trend, indicating a below-average labor demand. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative hours deviation suggests that the existing workforce is not experiencing an increase in workload.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.70%, ranking at the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 3.73%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not excessively. At the same time, workers are experiencing a moderate increase in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living ratio of \$170/sqft to \$33.17/hr, with a percentile rank of 92, indicating a highly affordable city. The fact that the PSF is falling by 4.0% YoY relative to wages makes it even more attractive. This high affordability score means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can be drawn without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of 0.10% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but only marginally. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may face some challenges in finding new talent, but the situation is not dire.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels has increased by 19.22% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 68 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This relatively fast market means that workers relocating to the city may face a competitive environment when searching for housing.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has an above-average share of professional and office workers, ranking at the 76th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may not be as suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the below-average labor demand, which may indicate a slower pace of economic growth and potentially weaker consumer demand.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.8th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		34
25% weight		
Unemployment		72
20% weight		
Wage Growth		22
15% weight		
Cost of Living		8
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		72
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		84
10% weight		
Days on Market		18
5% weight		
Office Economy		72
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.3% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.6% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +33.4% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 56 days median, -3.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.80 ranking it in the 34th percentile, and its high cost of living, with a ratio of \$490/sqft to \$40.91/hr, ranking it in the 8th percentile for affordability. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's economic landscape, with employment growth at +0.50% and weekly hours deviation at -0.202%.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in New York Newark-Jersey City is +0.50% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.202% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.80 ranks in the 34th percentile, indicating below-average labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in New York Newark-Jersey City is 4.30%, ranking it in the 72nd percentile, which means the market has some slack. This implies that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire in this city compared to others, but may not face significant wage pressure. The unemployment rate suggests a moderate level of competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in New York Newark-Jersey City is +1.91%, ranking it in the 22nd percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The wage growth rate is a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

New York Newark-Jersey City has a cost of living ratio of \$490/sqft to \$40.91/hr, with the price per square foot falling -0.6% year-over-year, ranking it in the 8th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living is a significant constraint for businesses looking to relocate or expand in this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in New York Newark-Jersey City is growing at a rate of +0.60% year-over-year, ranking it in the 72nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force provides a larger talent pool for companies to draw from.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in New York Newark-Jersey City has increased by +33.43% year-over-year, ranking it in the 84th percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rise in building permits is a positive indicator for the city's future housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in New York Newark-Jersey City is 56 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.5%. This relatively fast pace of home sales means that the market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges finding affordable housing. The days on market metric suggests that the city's housing market is still relatively hot.

Office Economy

New York Newark-Jersey City has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking it in the 72nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, but the high cost of living and stagnant wage growth are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain top talent.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.4th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)

Labor Demand		26
25% weight		
Unemployment		32
20% weight		
Wage Growth		32
15% weight		
Cost of Living		20
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		98
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		94
10% weight		
Days on Market		88
5% weight		
Office Economy		56
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +2.9%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.1%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +2.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +87.2%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +13.3% YoY 51 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 45.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth, with a 2.87% year-over-year increase, and its high building permits growth, with an 87.24% year-over-year change. These metrics signal a city with a expanding workforce and a confident developer community.

Labor Demand

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an employment growth rate of -0.12% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.351% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.13, which ranks in the 26th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours worked are below trend. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking in the 32nd percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. While the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, with some wage pressure likely. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that finding the right talent may require some effort, but it is not an extremely challenging market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 2.93%, which ranks in the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate is not extremely high, but it is still positive, suggesting that labor costs for employers are rising, albeit slowly. At the same time, worker purchasing power is increasing, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living score that ranks in the 20th percentile, with a PSF of \$458/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$45.83/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.99. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.5% year-over-year is a positive sign, but overall, the city's high cost of living may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% year-over-year, which ranks in the 98th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce. This means that the supply of potential employees is increasing, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need. This is a significant advantage for companies looking to hire in the city.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton has increased by 87.24% year-over-year, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to see an increase in available housing, which can improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.3%, ranking in the 88th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, with homes taking longer to sell. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that they may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier to find a home.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has an office economy score that ranks in the 56th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers of 2.70 out of 5. This indicates a moderate depth of professional talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less ideal for industrial or logistics-dominant companies.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a rapidly expanding workforce and a confident developer community, with a moderate level of wage growth and a relatively expensive cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

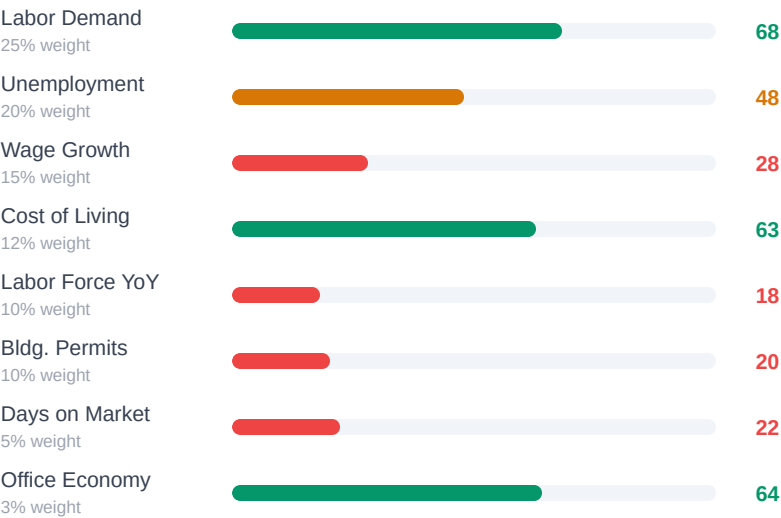
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

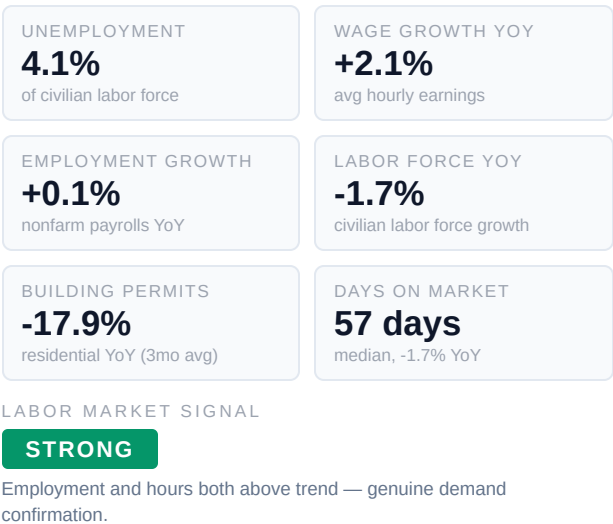
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.2th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.94, and its below-average wage growth, at 2.15% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a growing job market but relatively stagnant wages.

Labor Demand

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.10% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 1.564% above its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 ranks in the 68th percentile, further supporting the notion of a growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.10%, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent, which may drive up wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 2.15%, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The slow wage growth may make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking in the 63rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$280/sqft to \$43.51/hr, or 6.44. The fact that the PSF is falling by 3.5% year-over-year makes the city more affordable relative to peers. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -1.67% year-over-year, ranking in the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has decreased by 17.89% year-over-year, ranking in the 20th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 57 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.7%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 22nd percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract talent.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 64th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on specialized knowledge-economy workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant workforces.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a growing job market with relatively stagnant wages, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand without incurring high labor costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which may pose significant challenges in finding and retaining qualified workers to fill open positions.

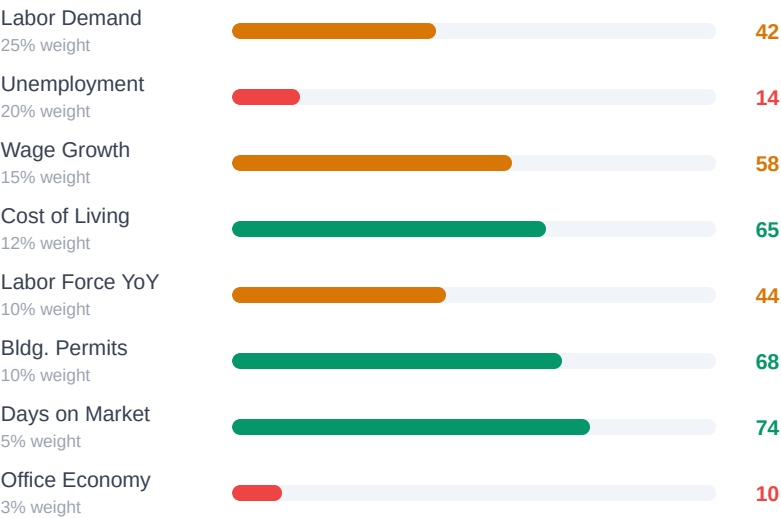
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

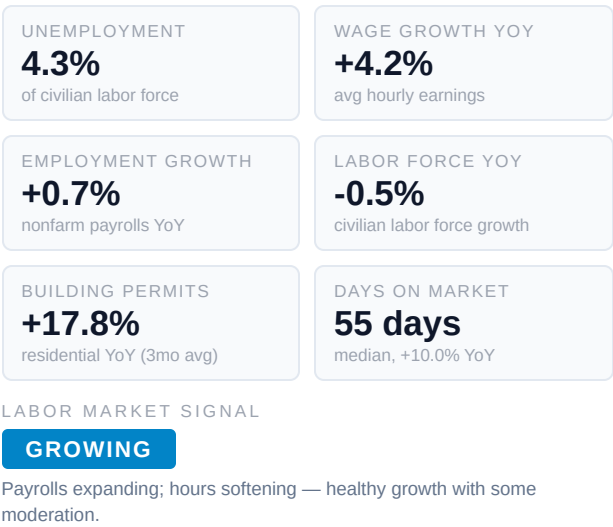
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.0th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 5.17, which is near the median at the 42nd percentile, and its high cost of living ratio of 4.98, ranking above average at the 65th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with moderate job growth but significant affordability challenges.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is +0.74% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.163% below trend. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, albeit with hours worked slightly below the 12-month baseline. The labor demand composite score of 5.17 reflects this balanced but not exceptional growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.30%, ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This suggests that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire, but it also implies weaker local consumer demand. Companies looking to staff up may find it relatively easier to do so here compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is +4.20% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers see a decent increase in their purchasing power. This balance suggests a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City's cost of living, with a PSF of \$171/sqft and an hourly wage of \$34.33, results in a ratio of 4.98, ranking above average at the 65th percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is more affordable than many of its peers, offering a talent attraction advantage without needing significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -0.50% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is not expanding. Businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent as the labor force shrinks.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are increasing by +17.78% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to see improvements in affordability and an easier time accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Oklahoma City are currently sitting on the market for 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.0%. This increase, placing the city at the 74th percentile, indicates a slower market where homes are not selling as quickly as they were. For workers relocating to the city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share is at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but might be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

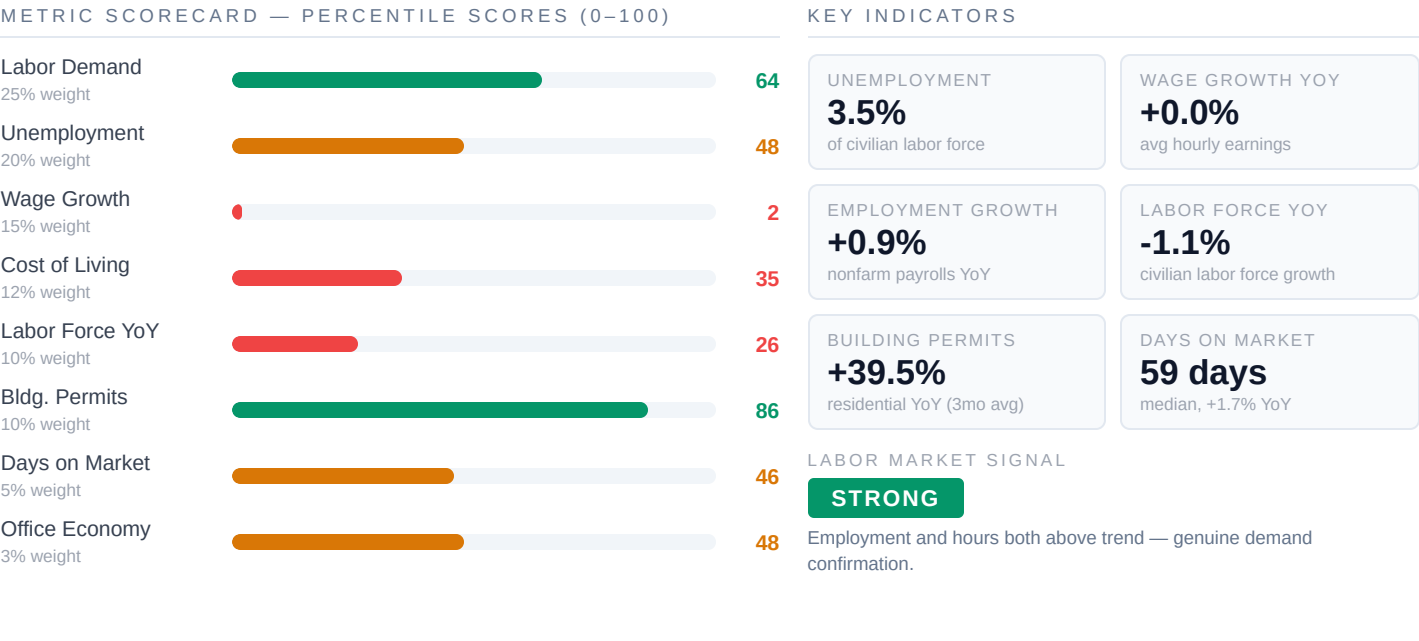
In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a business environment with moderate job growth, a relatively loose labor market, and a significant affordability advantage. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's shallow professional talent pool, which could limit the growth and competitiveness of certain types of businesses, particularly those reliant on a deep knowledge-economy workforce.

Birmingham

Birmingham

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.0th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 45.0th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.94, driven by a +0.92% employment growth rate and +0.349% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the +39.50% year-over-year change in building permits highlights a significant expansion in housing supply.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.92% and weekly hours deviation of +0.349% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination suggests that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 ranks in the 64th percentile, confirming this above-average demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham stands at 3.50%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced market, neither too tight nor too slack, implying that businesses may face moderate challenges in hiring but without extreme wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests a manageable but not overly competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.03%, Birmingham experiences stagnant wage growth, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This slow wage growth environment means labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a flat cost environment, but it may also indicate a less dynamic local economy.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$159/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$32.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.86, ranks below average at the 35th percentile. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The slight decrease in PSF of -0.6% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score suggests that talent attraction might require additional compensation to offset the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -1.10% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This negative growth rate, ranking in the 26th percentile, poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand or establish operations in Birmingham may face challenges in finding the necessary talent due to this contraction.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +39.50%, signaling a significant expansion in housing supply. This top-tier growth, ranking in the 86th percentile, is a positive indicator for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that Birmingham is likely to see improvements in housing availability and potentially slower rent growth.

Days on Market

Homes in Birmingham currently sit on the market for a median of 59 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%. This near-median ranking of 46th percentile indicates a relatively balanced market, neither too hot nor too cold. For workers relocating to this city, the market is moderately competitive, suggesting that finding a home might not be overly challenging but still requires timely decision-making.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share, with a composite score of 2.46, ranks near the median at the 48th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses requiring professional and office skills, but it may not be as competitive as cities with a higher concentration of such workers. Birmingham is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy, but it might not be the ideal location for those requiring a highly specialized or dense knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a mix of above-average labor demand and significant housing supply expansion, which could support business growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the stagnant wage growth and the contracting labor force, which may limit the city's ability to attract and retain top talent without additional incentives. Businesses considering Birmingham must weigh these factors carefully to determine if the city's overall economic character aligns with their strategic needs.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

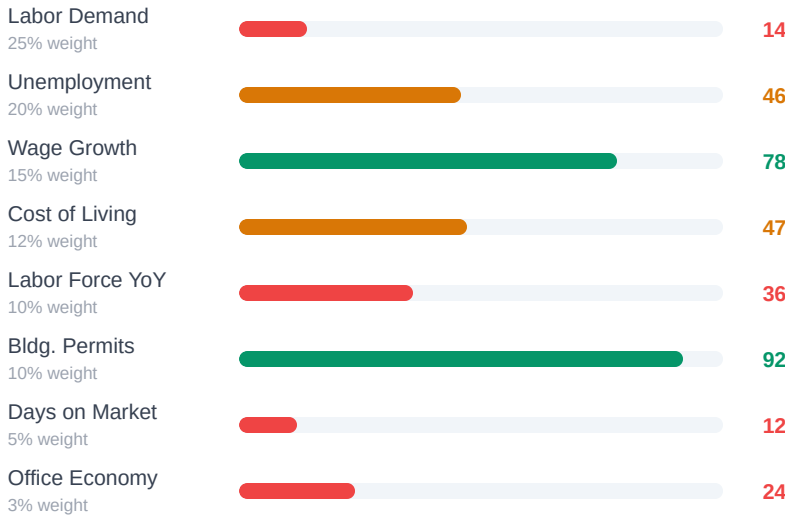
B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.2th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.6%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.9%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+77.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days
median, -2.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.51% in hourly earnings, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. These two metrics signal a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.55% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.174%, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.36 ranks in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, further emphasizing the weakness in labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor tightness. For a business trying to hire in this area, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding qualified workers may not be overly challenging, but it also may not be exceptionally easy.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 5.51%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses operating in this area should be prepared for increasing labor costs, but they can also expect a workforce with robust consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$224/sqft to \$35.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.27, and a percentile rank of 47, this city is near the median in terms of affordability. The PSF is increasing by 3.2% year-over-year, which does not favor affordability. This means that while the city is not exceptionally expensive or affordable compared to its peers, businesses may need to consider wage premiums to attract talent, especially given the rising cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking at a rate of -0.91% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should

anticipate challenges in finding and recruiting new employees due to this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is +77.17%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This significant increase in building permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. This is a positive indicator for businesses considering relocation, as it suggests that the area is likely to become more attractive to workers due to improving housing options.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 40 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.4%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicates that homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, the fast-paced housing market may make it challenging to find and secure a home, potentially affecting relocation decisions.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors, with a composite score of 1.88, ranks below average at the 24th percentile. This suggests that the professional talent pool, while present, is not as deep as in other metros. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a large pool of specialized office or tech talent but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex economic environment with strong wage growth but weak labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the challenge in hiring and retaining workers due to the contracting labor pool and relatively fast housing market. Despite these challenges, the area's strong wage growth and expanding housing supply due to increased building permits present opportunities for businesses that can adapt to these conditions.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

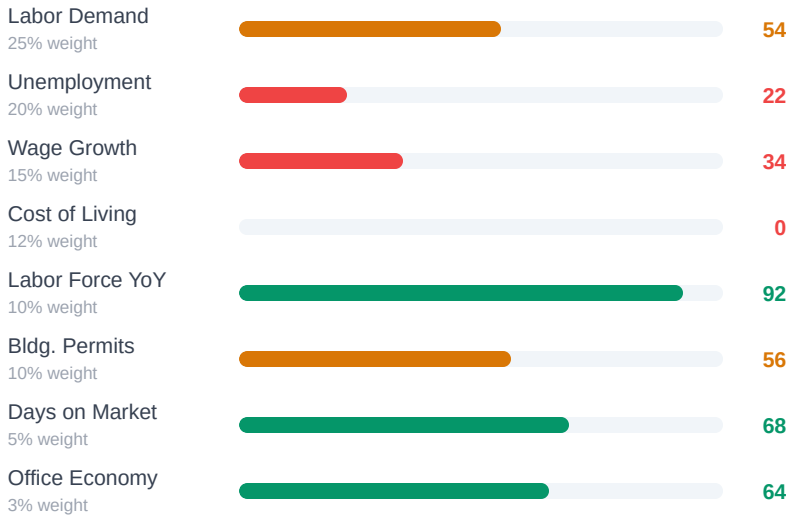
C+

POOR

43.1th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.6%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+1.7%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+6.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days

median, +2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY and its extremely low cost of living affordability score, ranking at the 0th percentile due to a PSF to earnings ratio of 9.94. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce but significant challenges in affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.326% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.47. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing. However, the growth rates are not exceptionally high, suggesting a moderate pace of economic activity.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it slightly easier to hire in this market compared to tighter labor markets, but the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +3.09%, ranking at the 34th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage growth. This rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a reasonable pace.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score ranking at the 0th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 9.94, driven by a PSF of \$362/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.41. This indicates that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% YoY, ranking at the 92nd percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to hire from, which can support hiring capacity and growth plans.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick is increasing by +5.95% YoY, ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which can help with affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 39 days, with a YoY increase of +2.6%, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be more accessible for relocating workers, as they have more time to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score ranking at the 64th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and a moderate pace of economic activity, but the extremely high cost of living poses a significant risk to talent attraction and retention. Decision-makers should carefully consider the need for wage premiums to compete in this market, as the city's affordability challenges may offset its other advantages.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

C+

POOR

41.8th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		52
Unemployment 20% weight		42
Wage Growth 15% weight		94
Cost of Living 12% weight		14
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		12
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		4
Days on Market 5% weight		28
Office Economy 3% weight		52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.7%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.5% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.8% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -37.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 45 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 41.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.50% year-over-year and its low cost of living affordability score, ranking at the 14th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.70% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.152% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a growing need for labor. However, the near-median percentile rank of 52nd suggests that this growth is not exceptionally strong compared to other metros.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.70%, ranking at the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a significant surplus of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.50%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating fast and strong wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score ranking at the 14th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$594/sqft vs \$44.28/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.41. Although the PSF is falling by 2.8% year-over-year, the city's affordability is still a concern. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is contracting at a rate of -1.75% year-over-year, ranking at the 12th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, which could limit their growth potential.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is -37.09%, ranking at the 4th percentile. This significant decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a constrained housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 45 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, ranking at the 28th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market may be competitive, making it essential for businesses to consider relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 52nd percentile, indicating a near-median depth of talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, including those in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses requiring a highly specialized or abundant knowledge-economy workforce.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a relatively expensive cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit growth potential and create challenges in finding available workers. As a result, businesses must carefully consider their hiring strategies and relocation incentives to succeed in this complex economic environment.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

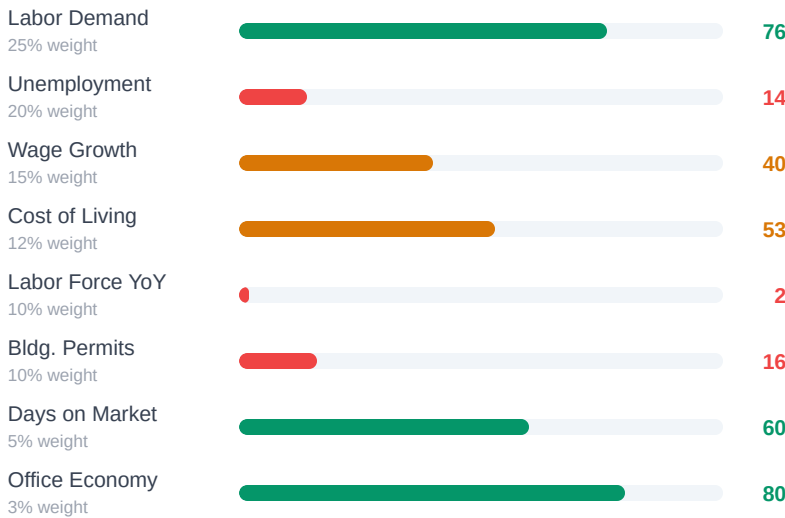
C+

POOR

41.4th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.9%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-2.7%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.8%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

67 days

median, -4.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile with a -2.70% year-over-year change. The labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, signal a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +0.91% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.771% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.28%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the pace of wage growth is not exceptionally high, which may limit the city's attractiveness to businesses seeking to minimize labor costs.

Cost of Living

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a cost of living score ranking in the 53rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$264/sqft to \$38.11/hr, or 6.93. The city's cost of living is near the median, neither exceptionally affordable nor expensive. The fact that PSF is falling -1.5% year-over-year relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs, but it also does not require substantial wage premiums to compensate for high living expenses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is shrinking at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is

decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies or consider relocating to areas with more expansive labor pools.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has decreased by -18.76% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and limitations in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend could negatively impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 67 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%, ranking in the 60th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers trying to find housing. However, the market is not excessively heated, suggesting some balance between supply and demand.

Office Economy

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 80th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge workers. Conversely, the city may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a mix of genuine labor demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool, but it also poses significant challenges due to its shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's labor force contraction, which may limit hiring capacity and require adaptive strategies to secure the necessary talent.

Memphis

Memphis

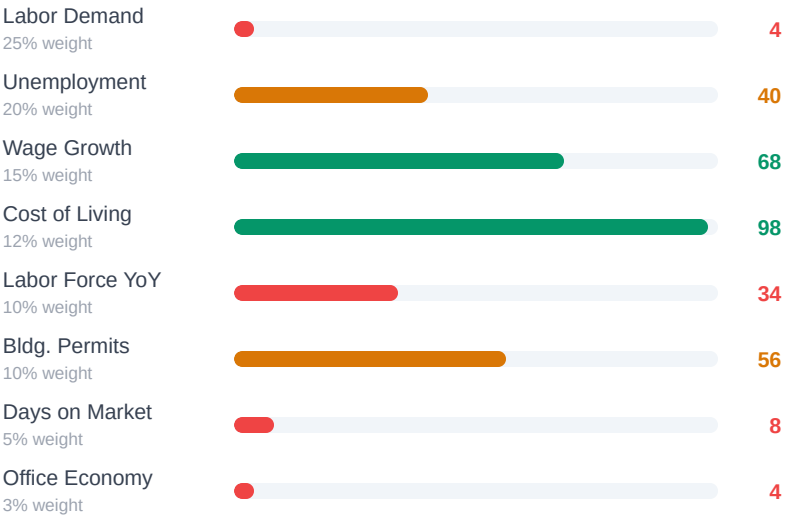
C+

POOR

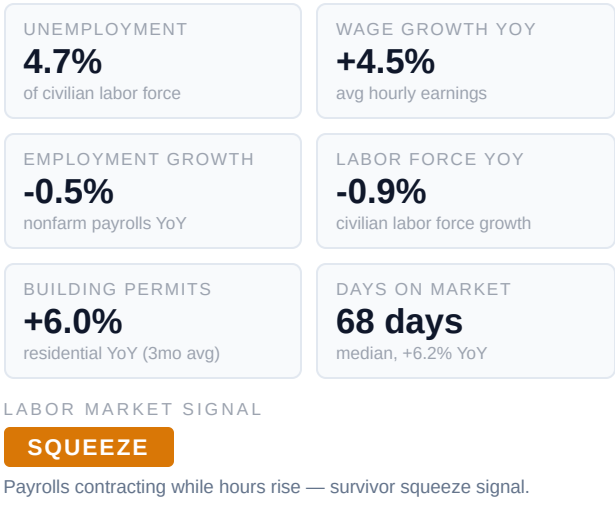
40.5th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.5th out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking in the top tier with a score of 98th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 2.11 and the cost of living ratio of \$153/sqft vs \$33.22/hr, with a PSF falling 4.4% YoY, are key metrics shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.49% YoY and weekly hours 1.586% above its own trend, indicating a contraction in job growth but with hours running above trend, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.11 is in the bottom tier, ranking 4th percentile, further emphasizing the lack of job growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.70%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is not a significant surplus of workers either. For a business trying to hire in Memphis, this means they may face some competition for talent but not to the extent seen in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

Memphis experiences a year-over-year wage growth of +4.52%, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This indicates that wages are rising faster than in most other cities, leading to increasing labor costs for employers. However, it also means that workers have stronger purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living score ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile, Memphis is more affordable relative to its peers. The PSF of \$153/sqft compared to average hourly earnings of \$33.22/hr, with a PSF falling 4.4% YoY, makes it an attractive location for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. This affordability can be a major advantage in attracting and retaining workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -0.92% YoY, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses looking to expand or establish operations in Memphis may face challenges in finding sufficient labor.

Building Permits

Memphis sees a year-over-year increase in residential building permits of +5.95%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This growth indicates that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce needs in the future. However, the moderate pace of growth may not entirely keep up with demand, potentially limiting the improvement in affordability.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis currently sit on the market for a median of 68 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.2%. This ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a slower market where homes take longer to sell. For workers relocating to Memphis, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, potentially easing the transition.

Office Economy

Memphis has a professional and office worker share ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that Memphis is less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, but may be more appropriate for industries with different labor requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a moderate unemployment rate, but it is constrained by low labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk for a decision-maker considering Memphis as a location is the challenge of finding and hiring sufficient labor due to the contracting labor force, which could hinder business growth and expansion plans.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

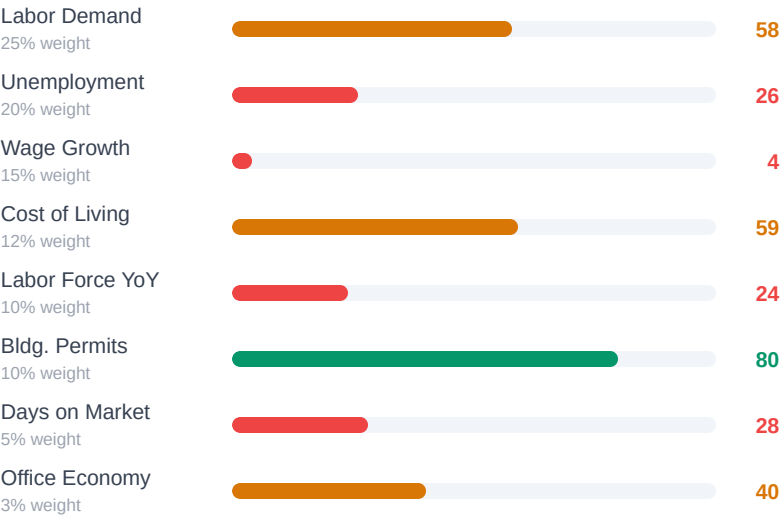
C+

POOR

40.4th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 40.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.57 and its bottom-tier wage growth of +0.27% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a mixed economic environment, with labor demand driven more by hours worked than job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.39% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.671% below the city's own trend. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as the growth in jobs is not accompanied by an increase in hours worked, suggesting some level of survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.40%, ranking it at the 26th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult for a business to hire here, the labor market is not as tight as in other cities, potentially leading to less wage pressure but also weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising quickly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score that ranks it at the 59th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$208/sqft to \$40.75/hr, or 5.10. The PSF has been falling by -1.9% year-over-year, making the city more affordable relative to its peers. This affordability could be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has been shrinking at a rate of -1.32% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing, which could exacerbate labor shortages in certain sectors.

Building Permits

The city has seen a +31.92% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This significant expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce, suggesting that the city is likely to remain attractive for relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

Homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington are currently sitting on the market for a median of 39 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranking at the 28th percentile, means that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when searching for housing, potentially making it tougher for businesses to attract talent without offering relocation assistance.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington ranks at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. However, the city may be less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, given its relatively lower ranking in these areas.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro offers a mixed bag for businesses, with affordability and expanding housing supply as positives, but stagnant wage growth and a shrinking labor force as significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited labor force growth, which could lead to hiring difficulties and labor shortages, potentially outweighing the benefits of locating in this metro area.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

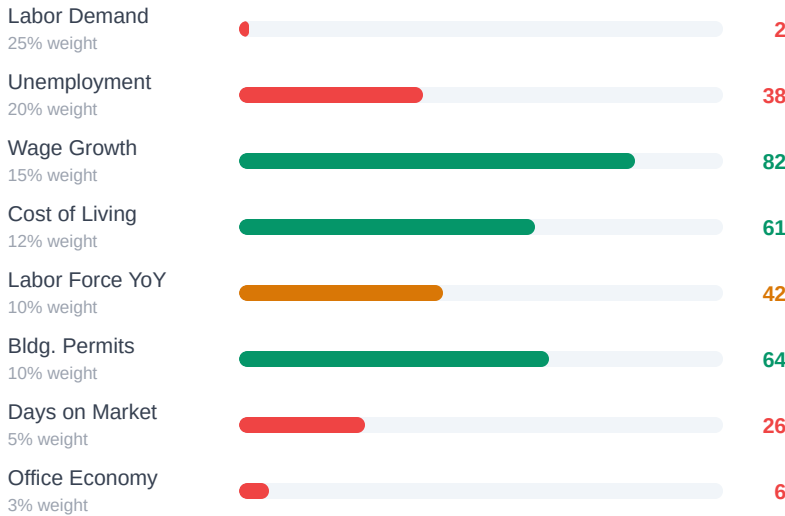
C+

POOR

39.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.6%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+12.6%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

61 days

median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.68%. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.52% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.368%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend during job losses indicating a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding talent to fill new roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, ranking it in the 38th percentile, indicating a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. This means that while there is some slack in the market, businesses may still face moderate competition for talent, and wage pressure may be present. However, it is still easier to hire in this market compared to tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.68%, ranking it in the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. However, this fast wage growth may also lead to higher labor costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score ranking it in the 61st percentile, with a PSF of \$304/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.15. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF (-2.2% YoY) contributing to its high affordability score. This makes it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -0.58% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by 12.62% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is expected to increase, which can improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.7%. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the area. However, this also suggests that the market may be normalizing, and businesses should not expect extremely fast turnover rates.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a professional and office worker share ranking it in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not rely heavily on professional or office workers, such as industrial or logistics companies, and may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a unique combination of relatively affordable living costs and high wage growth, but its low labor demand and contracting labor force pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for businesses in this area is the limited supply of workers, which can hinder rapid growth and expansion plans.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

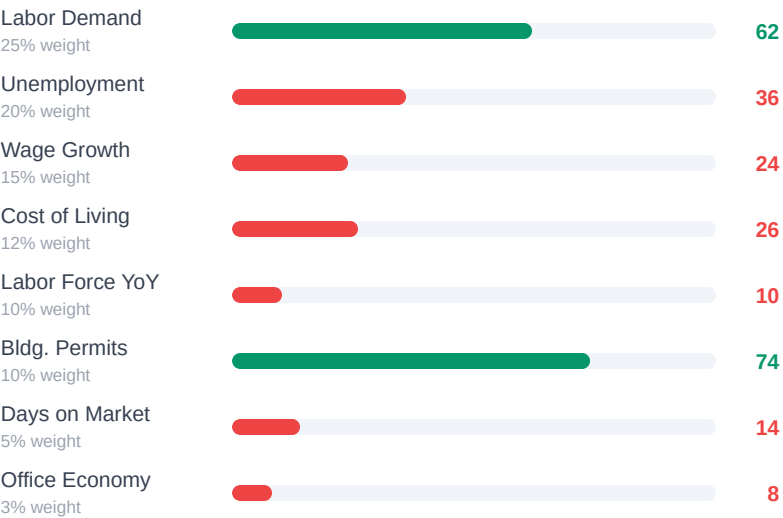
C+

POOR

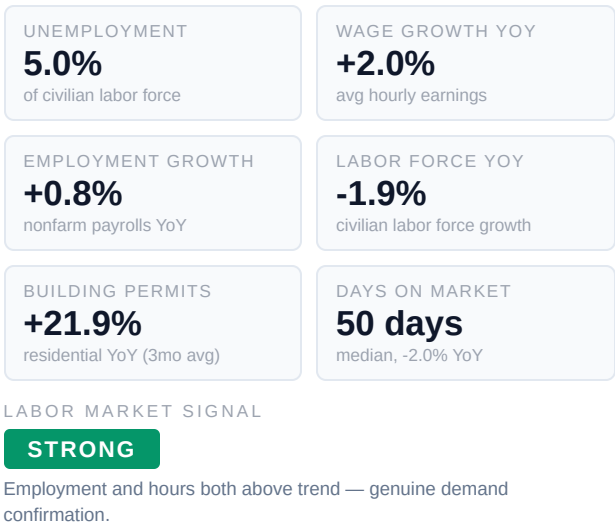
38.8th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 38.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 5.87 ranking it in the 62nd percentile, and its cost of living, which is in the 26th percentile due to a PSF to wages ratio of 8.82. The labor demand and cost of living metrics signal a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends in job growth but also challenges in affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.76% year-over-year, combined with a +0.508% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a moderate increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.87, ranking in the 62nd percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 5.00%, ranking in the 36th percentile, which indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, making it a relatively neutral environment for businesses trying to hire. However, the moderate unemployment rate may still pose some challenges for finding the right talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +2.02%, ranking in the 24th percentile, which is below average. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may face a relatively stable labor cost environment, but workers may not have strong bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score in the 26th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 8.82, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF is \$339/sqft, which has decreased by 0.9% year-over-year, slightly mitigating the affordability concerns. However, the overall affordability score suggests that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has contracted by -1.92% year-over-year, ranking in the 10th percentile, which indicates a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has increased by +21.94% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile, which suggests that housing supply is expanding. This growth in building permits is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it may help to alleviate some of the pressure on the housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.0%, ranking in the 14th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding and securing housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.78, ranking in the 8th percentile, which indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, but may not be ideal for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends in labor demand and building permits, but also challenges in affordability and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the shrinking labor pool, which may pose significant challenges for hiring and talent acquisition.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C

VERY POOR

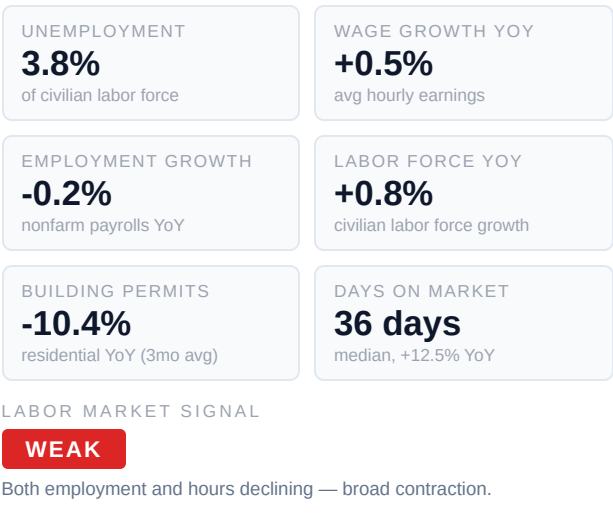
36.4th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.95 and an unemployment rate of 3.80%. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, with employment growth at -0.25% year-over-year and wage growth at +0.52% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.25% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.588% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a pace that would suggest genuine demand expansion. Instead, it may be experiencing a period of payrolls contracting or hours below trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, which is relatively low and corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 64th. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +0.52%, which is stagnant and ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could have implications for businesses relying on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that corresponds to a bottom-tier percentile rank of 6th, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.76, resulting in a ratio of 6.35. The PSF is increasing at a rate of +2.2% year-over-year. This makes the city relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could hinder talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +0.85% year-over-year, which is a top-tier growth rate ranking in the 80th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of

potential workers. However, the overall labor market conditions and other factors such as wage growth and cost of living must also be considered.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha has decreased by -10.38% year-over-year, which is below average and ranks in the 30th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding at a pace that would support future workforce growth, potentially leading to affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.5%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could make it easier for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend must be considered in the context of the overall job market and economic conditions.

Office Economy

Milwaukee-Waukesha has an office economy percentile rank of 30th, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements.

In conclusion, Milwaukee-Waukesha offers a growing labor force and a relatively slow housing market, which could be beneficial for businesses looking to relocate or expand. However, the city's low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and high cost of living are significant constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business operations. The single biggest risk is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living and slow wage growth.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

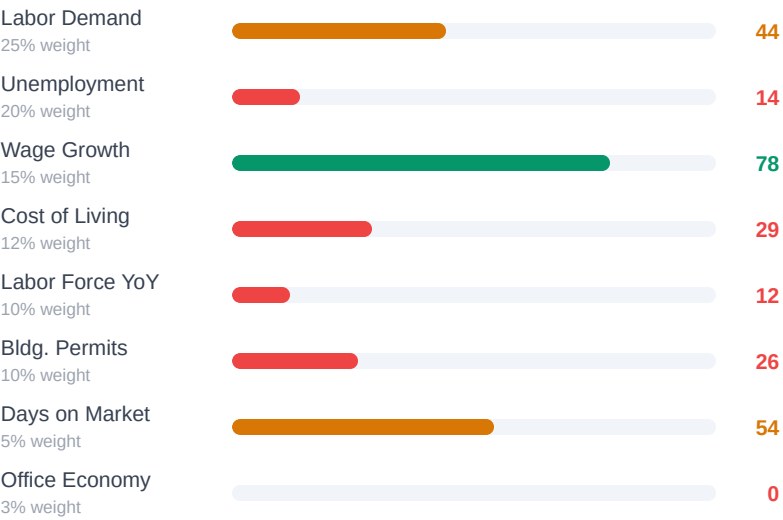
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VERY POOR

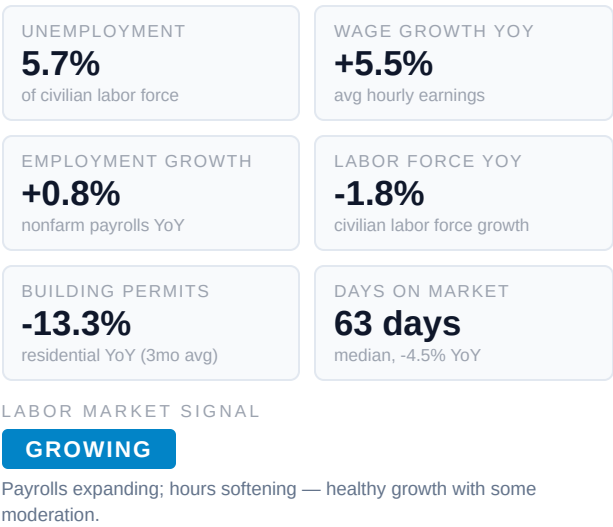
35.4th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.20. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.51% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 5.70%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging hiring environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.75% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, with some genuine demand for jobs but not excessively high. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 is near the median, indicating a balanced job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.70%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 14th percentile. This signals a tight labor market with limited slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.51%, which is above average, ranking 78th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which may lead to rising labor costs for employers. However, it also means that workers have strong purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score of 9.37, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$332/sqft to \$35.45/hr, which is below average, ranking 29th percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -1.2% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.75% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 12th percentile. This indicates a shrinking labor pool, which may create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is falling -13.30% year-over-year, which is below average, ranking 26th percentile. This signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining workers who are relocating to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.5%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the near-median percentile rank of 54th suggests that the market is not excessively competitive, and workers may still find affordable options.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a professional and office worker share of 0.16, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 0th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making the city less suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy talent, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a tight labor market, which can be both a blessing and a curse. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this area is the shrinking labor pool and tightening housing supply, which may create challenges in attracting and retaining talent. As a result, businesses should carefully consider these factors when making location decisions and develop strategies to mitigate these risks.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

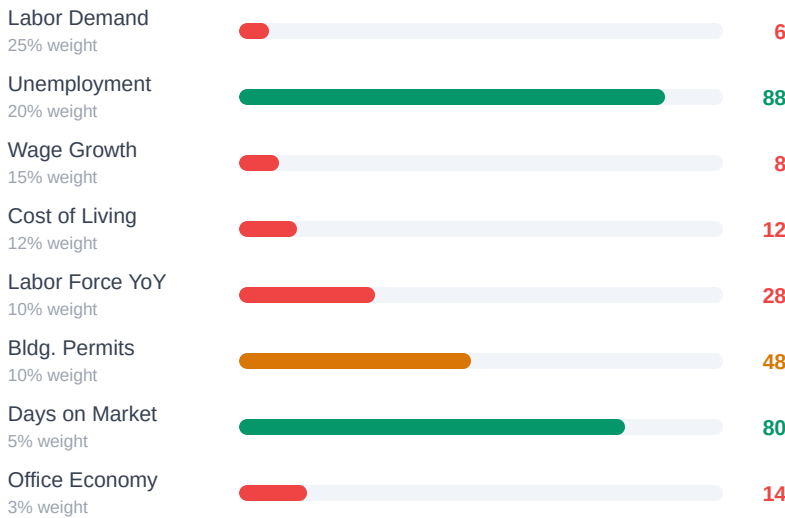
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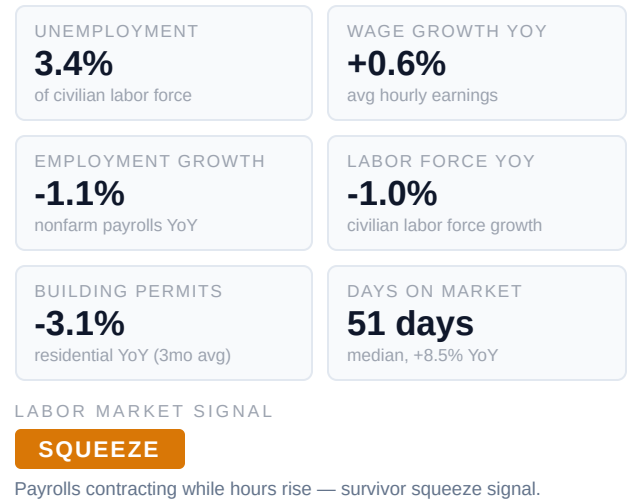
33.8th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking in the 33.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.36, indicating a struggling job market. The two metrics that most define this city's current economic character are its negative employment growth rate of -1.05% and low wage growth of +0.58%. These numbers suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.05%, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.471%, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 2.36, ranking in the 6th percentile, further emphasizes the weakness in the job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer higher salaries to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.58%, ranking in the 8th percentile, which is stagnant compared to other metros. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers will remain relatively flat, but workers will have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the purchasing power to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score ranking in the 12th percentile, with a PSF of \$165/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$33.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.87. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 4.4% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -0.99% year-over-year, ranking in the 28th percentile. This decline in labor force supply means that businesses may face structural headwinds when trying to hire, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has decreased by -3.15% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 51 days, with an 8.5% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 80th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also signal a weakening demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, ranking in the 14th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, the city may be more attractive to industries with less specialized labor requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood offers a relatively low-cost business environment, but its struggling job market, slow wage growth, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor force growth and shallow talent pool, which may hinder a company's ability to attract and retain skilled workers.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

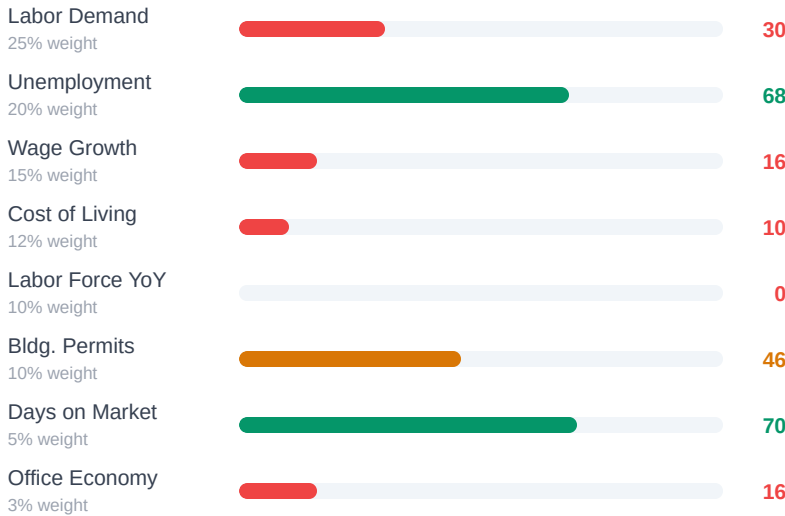
C

VERY POOR

33.3th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-7.5%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-3.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

38 days

median, +2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking in the 33.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.59. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, with employment growth at +0.68% year-over-year and weekly hours deviating -0.658% from its own trend. The combination of these metrics signals a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.68% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of -0.658% from its own trend indicate a lack of genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the labor market is not experiencing significant growth, and the decrease in hours worked implies a potential contraction. The labor demand composite score of 4.59, ranking in the 30th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.30%, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it more challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +1.41%, ranking in the 16th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power and purchasing power is not increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$217/sqft to \$32.58/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.66, and a percentile rank of 10th, Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living eats into the purchasing power of workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -7.49% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential employees is decreasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -3.73%, indicating a slight tightening of housing supply. Although this decline is not drastic, it still signals that the future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk if the trend continues.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.7%, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city to find housing.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 1.38, ranking in the 16th percentile, Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers a relatively tight labor market with slow wage growth, making it challenging for businesses to hire and retain talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the shrinking labor force, which poses a significant structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support business growth. Overall, businesses considering this location must carefully weigh the potential benefits against the labor market challenges.

Fresno

Fresno

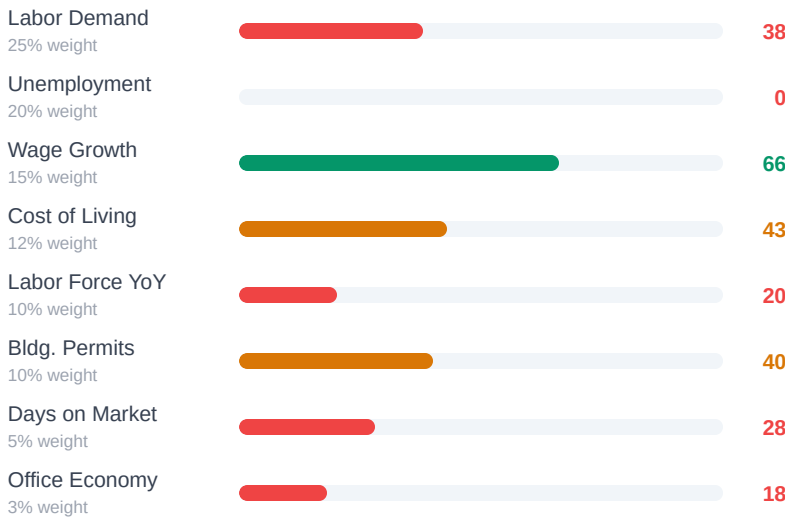
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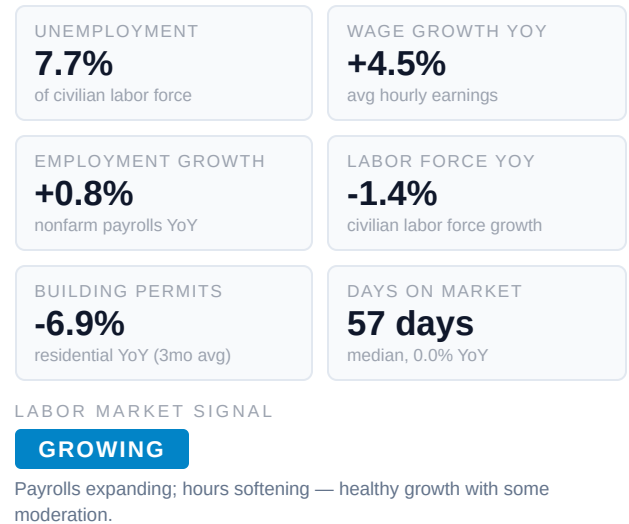
32.5th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno, with an overall grade of C and a composite score ranking it 32.5th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its below-average labor demand and high unemployment rate, with 7.70% of the labor force unemployed. The labor demand composite score of 4.90 and unemployment rate are the two metrics that most define this city's current economic character, with the latter being a significant concern for businesses looking to hire. Specifically, the combination of a low labor demand score and high unemployment rate suggests a challenging environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is +0.79% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.503% below the city's own trend, indicating a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than a survivor squeeze, as hours are below trend despite some job growth. The labor demand composite score of 4.90 is below average, ranking 38th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is the lowest percentile rank, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that the market is not tight, and businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The high unemployment rate has a practical implication for businesses trying to hire, as they may have a larger pool of potential candidates to choose from.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Fresno is +4.51% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 66th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, which implies rising labor costs for employers, but also good news for worker purchasing power. As wages rise, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive, while workers may see an increase in their disposable income.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks 43rd percentile, with a PSF of \$263/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$34.06/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.72. This means that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor cheap compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising +0.4% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that affordability may be decreasing over time. This has implications for talent attraction, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is shrinking at a rate of -1.42% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is decreasing, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As the labor force contracts, businesses may need to compete more aggressively for a smaller pool of potential candidates.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno is decreasing at a rate of -6.89% year-over-year, which signals a tightening of the housing supply. This decrease in permits may lead to a supply squeeze in the future, making it more difficult for workers to find affordable housing and potentially eroding the city's attractiveness to relocating workers. The near-median percentile rank of 40th suggests that this trend is not drastically different from other cities.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 57 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, indicating a relatively stable market. However, the below-average percentile rank of 28th suggests that homes are selling relatively quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. This could be a concern for businesses looking to attract talent from outside the area.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share is relatively low, ranking 18th percentile, indicating a shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a unique combination of below-average labor demand and high unemployment, which may make it an attractive location for businesses looking for a large pool of potential candidates. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the city's shrinking labor force, which may pose significant challenges for hiring and expansion. Decision-makers should carefully consider this factor when evaluating Fresno as a potential location for their business.

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

30.4th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		8
Unemployment 20% weight		54
Wage Growth 15% weight		30
Cost of Living 12% weight		22
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		32
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		62
Days on Market 5% weight		6
Office Economy 3% weight		22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.8%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +2.4%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.8%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -0.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +10.3%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -4.3% YoY 44 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.93 ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its below-average wage growth of +2.40% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.82% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.219%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation. The positive deviation in weekly hours may suggest a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.40%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not as quickly as in other metros.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking at the 22nd percentile, with a PSF of \$228/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.92, resulting in a ratio of 6.35. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by +1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.94% year-over-year, indicating that the workforce supply is shrinking. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified candidates to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Richmond is increasing by +10.33% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better

affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is 44 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. The decreasing days on market suggests that homes are selling quickly, which could pose challenges for relocating employees to find suitable housing.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share ranks at the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more accommodating to industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Richmond metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses, with some challenges in labor demand and cost of living, but also opportunities in expanding housing supply and a relatively balanced labor market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and shrinking workforce supply, which could hinder hiring capacity and business growth.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

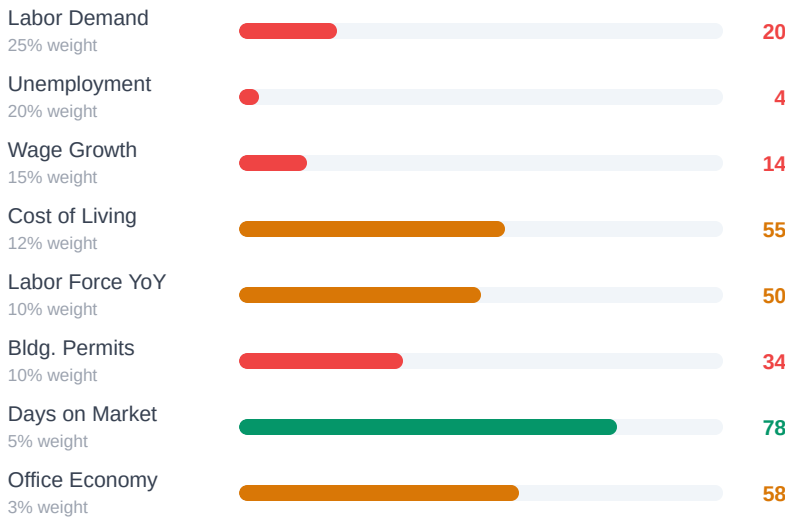
C-

CRITICAL

28.6th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.3%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.3%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-10.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

65 days

median, -12.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 28.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.86, and its high unemployment rate of 4.90%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is a modest +0.06% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.520% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 3.86, ranking in the 20th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This indicates a market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Jacksonville is +1.34% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score ranking it in the 55th percentile, with a PSF of \$214/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.71. The city's PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year, which contributes to its relatively affordable ranking. This means that Jacksonville has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live in the city without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is shrinking at a rate of -0.29% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find workers.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Jacksonville are falling -10.28% year-over-year, ranking in the 34th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 65 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.2%, ranking in the 78th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing days on market suggests that the market may be normalizing.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks in the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. The city is relatively well-suited for businesses that do not require a highly specialized knowledge-economy workforce, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on a deep pool of professional talent.

In conclusion, Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a large pool of potential workers due to its high unemployment rate. However, the city's low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and shrinking labor force supply pose significant risks and constraints for businesses looking to expand or relocate, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating Jacksonville as a potential location.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

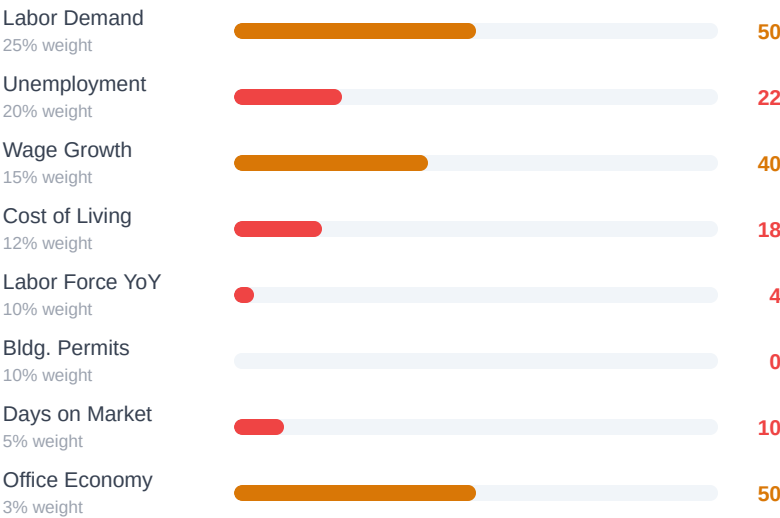
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CRITICAL

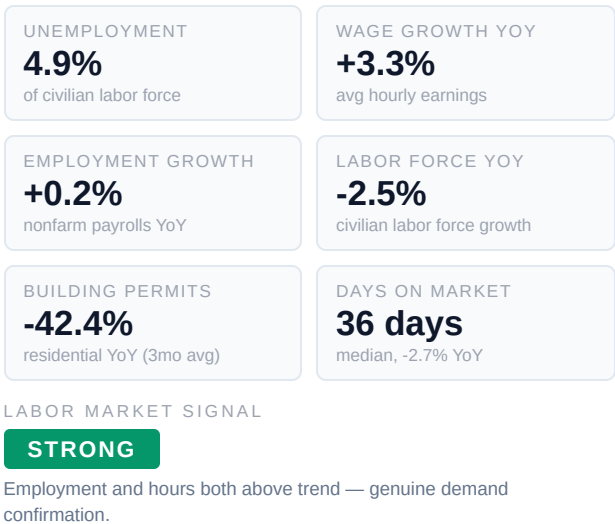
27.5th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking at the 27.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor force growth rate of -2.46% YoY and its bottom-tier cost of living score, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.87, indicating a relatively expensive market. The labor demand composite score of 5.43, near the median, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.22% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.823% from its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that jobs are being added, and hours are running above trend, suggesting a moderate level of labor demand. The near-median percentile rank of 50th percentile for labor demand composite score further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.90%, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may face moderate wage pressure. The relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros suggests that the market is not overly tight.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.28%, ranking at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. The moderate wage growth rate may attract businesses looking for a balance between labor cost management and worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score ranking at the 18th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.87, indicating a relatively expensive market. The PSF is \$221/sqft, increasing by 3.8% YoY, which may deter talent attraction without wage premiums. The low affordability score suggests that businesses may need to offer higher salaries to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -2.46% YoY, ranking at the 4th percentile, indicating a significant decline in the workforce supply. This contraction implies that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face challenges in finding

qualified talent. The low labor force growth rate is a concern for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has decreased by 42.35% YoY, ranking at the 0th percentile, indicating a severe tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain talent. The lack of new housing developments may exacerbate the existing affordability issues.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 36 days, with a YoY decrease of 2.7%, ranking at the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low percentile rank suggests that the market is competitive, and workers may need to act quickly to secure housing.

Office Economy

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has an office economy score ranking at the 50th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This city is suited for businesses that require a balance of office and non-office sectors, but may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized professional or office roles. The moderate ranking suggests that the city has a diverse economy, but may not be a hub for tech, finance, or consulting industries.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers a moderate labor demand and wage growth, but its low labor force growth rate and expensive cost of living are significant concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited workforce supply and potential affordability issues, which may impact their ability to attract and retain talent.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

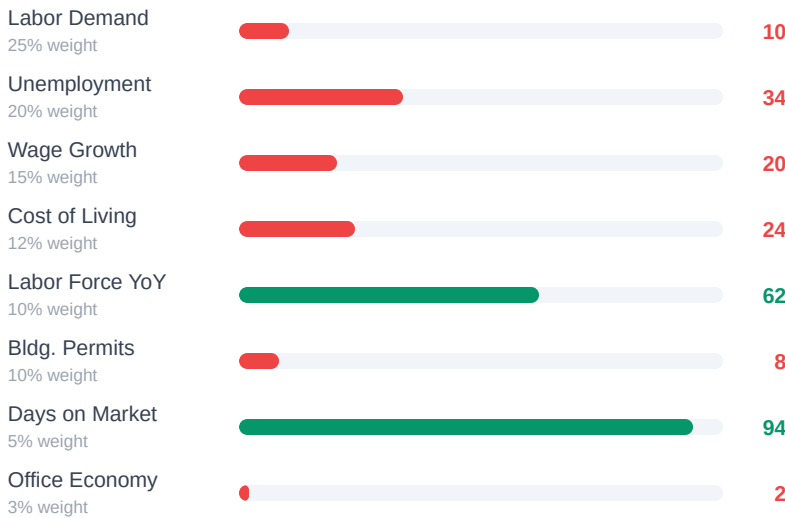
C-

CRITICAL

27.0th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.2%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-31.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days

median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 27.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its slow wage growth, at +1.74% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.13% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +1.140%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This suggests that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.80%, ranking in the 34th percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The labor market is not tight, giving employers some flexibility in hiring and wage setting.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is +1.74%, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating slow wage growth. This means that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a moderate pace, and worker purchasing power is not increasing rapidly. The slow wage growth may limit the attractiveness of the city to businesses looking for a highly skilled and highly paid workforce.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking it in the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$178/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$31.41, resulting in a ratio of 5.67. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent attraction without wage premiums. The cost of living is a concern for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.25% year-over-year, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, providing a positive implication for hiring capacity. Businesses may find it easier to attract and retain workers in the area due to the growing labor force.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County has decreased by -31.66% year-over-year, ranking in the 8th percentile. This signals a tightening of the housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain workers in the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Louisville-Jefferson County is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.8%, ranking in the 94th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.32, ranking in the 2nd percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors. The city's economy is more dominated by industrial or logistics sectors, making it more attractive to businesses in those fields.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively low-cost labor market with some slack, but also slow wage growth and a tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and limited professional talent pool, which may limit the attractiveness of the city to businesses looking for a highly skilled and highly paid workforce.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

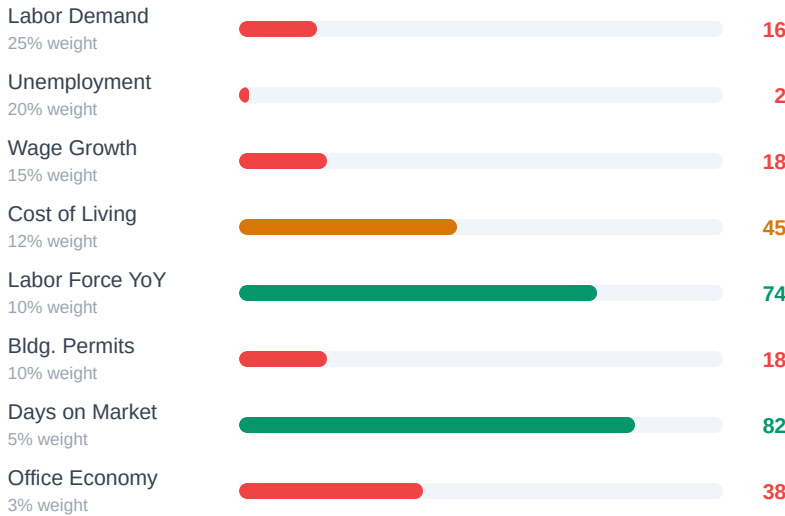
C-

CRITICAL

26.9th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

6.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-18.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

40 days
median, +5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 26.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high unemployment rate of 6.00%, which is in the bottom tier as well. The labor demand composite score of 3.58 and unemployment rate of 6.00% suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.20% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.439%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 6.00%, which is in the bottom tier, indicating a significant amount of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the high unemployment rate. With an unemployment rate this high, businesses may have an advantage in terms of hiring, but may also face challenges in terms of local demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.48%, which is in the bottom tier, indicating stagnant wage growth. This means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the purchasing power to drive local demand.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score in the 45th percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.53/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.96. This means that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor affordable compared to its peers. As a result, businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to cost of living, and may need to consider wage premiums to attract top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 74th percentile. This means that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. With a growing

labor force, businesses may have access to a larger pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is decreasing by -18.71% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may face challenges in terms of attracting and retaining workers due to limited housing options.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%, ranking in the 82nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, this may mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 2.24, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and a relatively slow housing market, but also poses significant challenges due to its low labor demand and high unemployment rate. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential difficulty in finding the right talent and the limited housing options, which may impact their ability to attract and retain workers.